The Final War

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/51552496.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Glimmadora - Freeform, Glimadora - Freeform, Dreams and Nightmares, Protective Glimmer (She-Ra), Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Girls in Love, Adora is in Love with Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora and Catra are Siblings (She-Ra), Canon Rewrite, glimmadora endgame obviously, Angst with a Happy Ending, Warning: Horde Prime (She-Ra), Trauma, discussion of trauma, background bowfuma, catra's redemption is written differently in this fic

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by orphan_account

Summary

After a brief confrontation in the Fright Zone, Adora and Catra find themselves on Horde Prime's ship. Horde Prime threatens to destroy Etheria.

Adora can no longer turn into She-Ra using the broken Sword of Protection.

Glimmer and Adora develop feelings for each other.

Catra realizes that she cannot escape the consequences of her actions forever.

Notes

The idea of this fic came to me in a dream. I think it'll have nine chapters. Only time will tell, though.

See the end of the work for more notes

Miles Apart

The moment Adora shattered the sword, she couldn't go back. Its cracking sound replayed in her ears. It was a blur. Light Hope spoke to her before vanishing. She was sure the hologram said "thank you." Racing out of the Crystal Castle, her grip on the golden hilt remaining tight, she thought of Glimmer. She had to get to her and Bow. The blonde proceeded past the trees, panting. It would be nice to have She-Ra's strength right now. A half-hour passed, and she stumbled into the Fright Zone.

"Hello?" Adora shouted. "Glimmer? Bow?"

There was no response. What if something happened? Adora stormed into the headquarters, avoiding the rubble. The duo was nowhere to be found. Panting, she made her way to the sanctum. Hordak lingered underneath a pile of rubble, and Catra leaned against the wall. The magicat's ears perked up at the sound of Adora's footsteps. Hordak mumbled something under his breath.

"Where are Glimmer and Bow?" Adora demanded as she approached Catra. She gripped the magicat's shirt, her fingers sinking into the fabric. "Did you do something to them?" She pointed the broken blade at Catra's chest.

Catra hissed, clawed hands enveloping Adora's wrist as her heterochromia eyes glowered into the blonde's bright blue eyes. The brunette bared her fangs, nostrils flaring as her ears flattened against her skull.

"They left," Catra said.

"What do you mean they left?" Adora spat.

"Bow helped Glimmer leave. Maybe they went to Bright Moon."

Adora clenched her jaw, hoping Catra was telling her the truth and not playing mind games. She had never forgotten the time Catra interrupted Princess Prom and kidnapped her friends. What

if Catra was lying? Before Adora could say something, Catra rammed a knee into her abdomen, forcing her to loosen her grip. The golden hilt slipped from Adora's hand and collided against the metal floor.

"Why don't you back off, blondie?" Catra spat as she flashed her claws.

"Because I don't trust you!" Adora replied.

"I figured you would overreact. You really are the world's worst She-Ra."

Adora's heart skipped a beat as she took in the words. She had heard Catra say such words in the portal reality. A sickly green glow enveloped both women and the unconscious warlord. Was this another Horde trick? An invisible force lifted them upward, and as she reached for the broken sword, the ground disappeared beneath them. The light obscured everything around her. What was going on? Bracing for the impact, she squeezed her eyes shut. Within seconds, she felt her palms resting against a cold surface.

Eyes fluttering open, Adora took in her surroundings. The entire hall was crisp and clean. Anyone could see their reflection on the floor. Where was she? A looming figure towered over a kneeling Hordak. Whoever the stranger was, they were decked out in white. Four green eyes observed Hordak's body language.

"Horde Prime, I conquered Etheria," Hordak said.

Adora rose to her height. Prime emitted an aura of wickedness. As Horde Prime and Hordak spoke to each other, the former's hair tubes emerged from behind. She glanced around, searching for an exit. There wasn't a way to leave this place. Catra made eye contact. The magicat seemed as confused as Adora felt. A scream of agony drew the women's attention to Hordak. He reclined, unconscious.

"Take him to reconditioning," Horde Prime ordered the guards.

The clones whisked Hordak away without a word. Adora straightened her spine as she stepped forward. Since she had no idea where her golden hilt was, she would have to figure out another way to leave. Horde Prime was dangerous, and there was no denying the obvious.

Horde Prime whirled around. "Looks like I have guests. A kitty and a blonde, if I'm not mistaken."

"What are you going to do to us?" Adora asked in a steely voice, despite her rising fear. "What do you want?"

If Horde Prime was anything like Hordak, he would imprison someone if such a person arrived. The hairs on Adora's neck stood as his eyes scrutinized her. She couldn't show him any ounce of nervousness. All she could do was wait for the answer. Well, she could always outsmart him and flee the hall.

"I desire peace and order," Horde Prime said.

"Does it mean you'll release us?" Adora asked.

Horde Prime snickered. "You are on my ship, the Velvet Glove. You and the kitty are guests. And you hope to leave? A power on your planet alerted me to its existence. I can sense the warrior within you. I have use for Etheria."

"I broke my sword. No one's using me as a weapon."

Horde Prime placed his icy fingers on Adora's chin. "Are you the key to Etheria's power?"

Catra approached Horde Prime. "She-Ra is the key." She pointed a thumb at Adora. "The other princesses activated the power. It's a huge superweapon. If you want to learn how to use it, you need me."

"Good to know, little sister. You have a place in my army. Hopefully She-Ra is willing to be an asset," Horde Prime said.

Adora shook her head. "Prime, you're wrong. I won't help you."

"Why do you want to go back?"

"Etheria needs me." Adora sounded unhappier than she hoped to come across. She intended to appear confident and unafraid. However, her voice implied otherwise. What good was she if she couldn't transform into She-Ra anymore?

Horde Prime caressed Adora's cheek. "Why do you wish to return? I can hear the pain in your voice. You will stay in one of the guest rooms and consider my offer, She-Ra. I will not cause you any hurt and sorrow. You will be happy to work for me."

"Don't touch me!" Adora blurted out. She swung a fist at Horde Prime's forearm. "I'd rather protect Etheria from you!"

Horde Prime caught Adora's fist before she could punch him. She launched her other fist at him; his hair tentacles sprung forward, wrapping around her neck. Goosebumps formed on Adora's skin as she struggled to break free. The tentacles tightened their hold, forcing the air out of her lungs.

"Don't kill Adora," Catra said. "You told her she could be an asset to your army, correct? Let's keep her around."

Horde Prime's tentacles retracted, freeing Adora's neck. "I suppose we will, little sister." He held up a palm. "Little brothers, take our guest to one of the rooms!"

The clones entered the hall, grabbed Adora, and escorted her to a corridor. She struggled against their grip. They refused to let go. Heart pounding against her ribs, she attempted to remember a strategy that would help her outsmart a pair of captors. However, her mind couldn't cooperate. Should she try to awaken the power within her? Razz once told her the weapon was inside her.

Before Adora could do anything, the clones imprisoned her in a windowless cell. How long would she be in here? Would her friends know she was missing? If so, were they searching for her?

Or did they feel abandoned? She couldn't remain in captivity forever. Taking a deep breath, she held out her hand, trying to channel her power.

"For the honor of Grayskull," Adora murmured, anticipating a transformation.

Unfortunately, Adora didn't transform. Why couldn't she do it? Tears blurred her vision. Checking every wall for an opening, she found none. She charged at the barrier, swearing at whoever was on the other side of the force field. However, no amount of pounding and kicking would make it budge. She descended to her knees, sobbing as she buried her face in her hands.

Adora should have returned to Bright Moon when Catra mentioned her friends leaving the Fright Zone. She should have paid more attention to her surroundings. Instead, she was laser-focused on confronting Catra. The result? She let herself become Horde Prime's prisoner. Footsteps echoed past her cell. It could be a clone, or it could be Catra. The force field whirred, garnering her attention as she stood. Heterochromia eyes peered at her. Anger washed over her as she crossed her arms.

"Someone's been crying. Not so strong and mighty anymore, are you?" Catra taunted.

"Leave me alone!" Adora shouted.

Catra snorted. "Why should I? It's no different from you being a prisoner in the Fright Zone."

"Did you know any of this would happen?"

"No. Prime took us by surprise. Guess we didn't pay attention."

Adora wished she could turn into She-Ra and break out of this cell. That way, she would sock Catra. Yet Adora couldn't do it. All she could do was wait for someone to come to the rescue or for an opportunity to flee. Catra definitely wouldn't help her anytime.

Who put her through so much pain? Catra did. Who hurt her friends and the rest of Etheria? The same person did.

"Now you're mad," Catra said, snickering. "I better go."

"Go ahead. I'd rather not talk to you," Adora replied in a shaky voice.

Adora found herself staring at the force field, seeing nothing but green. The magicat's footsteps receded. It was better to be lonely than to talk to the person who scarred her and trapped Queen Angella in the portal reality. She strode to the cot and sat. The cold air snaked into her jacket, making her shiver. How long would Horde Prime and his clones keep her hostage? If not for her situation, she would have been talking to Glimmer, despite arguing many times. Her heart ached at the memories of every quarrel. What happened to their closeness? Where did Adora go wrong as a friend and as a hero? She knew Angella told her to take care of the queen. Maybe Adora went overboard, but at least the blonde tried her best to protect Glimmer. Was she destined to be a failure no matter what she did?

Adora's best hadn't been good enough for her friends and the rest of Etheria. Ever since she found the sword, everything had gone wrong. What if she never touched the weapon? Would things have been different? There was no going back in time. Unless she could somehow awaken the weapon within her, she was useless. As long as she stayed in here, she couldn't do anything. It wasn't too different from her capture in the Crimson Waste. Because of Adora's inability to escape the cuffs and grab the sword back then, her enemy had activated the portal. The result? Angella lost her life while snatching the sword in the crumbling portal world.

Heroes shouldn't be rotting away in prisons, awaiting rescue. Adora didn't have a good feeling about the fate of Etheria now that Horde Prime discovered the planet. She ran her hands through her hair, sniffling. Teardrops fell on her lap, forming small dark spots on her pants. Inhaling deeply, she glanced at the

barrier. No opportunity to outsmart a captor. Just more footsteps and muffled conversations.

Catra contemplated a plan as she walked through an intersection and past the doors. She could rise in the ranks, as she once did in the Etherian Horde. If only Horde Prime carried a weakness. It wouldn't be wise to ask him. She would have to wait for the moment. Even in space, gaining control was her goal. As for Adora, she could get rid of her if she rose to the top. Soon, she entered a spacious throne room where Horde Prime sat. Her tail bristled, and she smoothed the hairs. Despite the lack of proximity, she sensed him watching her.

"Greetings, little sister," Horde Prime said.

Catra closed the distance between both individuals and kneeled before Prime's throne. "Greetings, Lord Prime."

"A brother has told me you have been communicating with the prisoner."

Catra's ears perked. "Is it a problem?"

Horde Prime chuckled. "The two of you were close once, weren't you? According to a brother's memory, you and She-Ra worked for him. You grew up together. And one day, she left."

"Adora doesn't matter to me. I hate her. And she hates me, too," Catra said, glowering at Horde Prime. "What matters is getting her to consider your offer. I suspect she won't agree to join the Galactic Horde."

Horde Prime stroked his chin, seemingly deep in thought. Then, he said, "Do what you can to earn the weapon's trust. I'll speak to her later."

"She told me to quit bothering her."

"Don't let her words repel you. If she continues resisting, I'll take drastic measures."

Catra rose to her height and shrugged. Adora would shout at her again, and the blonde would refuse to listen. As far as she could tell, there wouldn't be any chance of getting through to her enemy. Catra strode out of the throne room, tail swishing back and forth with each step. Would she come up with anything that would get Adora to listen? On another note, what did Prime mean by drastic measures? What did he have in mind? The blonde wasn't a clone like Hordak and the others.

Catra stumbled into a hallway containing dozens of cells. She was here before. Horde Prime had given her a task. However, Adora wouldn't be receptive. At some point, she heard Adora screaming. The blonde sounded angry. A dull thud resounded. Was Adora trying to escape? Catra stepped toward Adora's cell and slid her palm along the barrier, revealing her enemy.

"How are your escape attempts going?" Catra asked, smirking.

"Here to taunt me more?" Adora replied, vibrating with rage.

"Horde Prime will talk to you soon. He wants to know if you agree to join his army."

"I will never betray my friends. I won't let him win."

"And how would you stop him? I haven't seen you transform into She-Ra after Prime beamed us onto his ship. You said you broke the sword."

Adora released an audible exhale. "I know. And I won't let the lack of a sword hinder me. I've fought without one."

Catra recalled Adora confronting Horde Prime. "And how did it turn out for you? He was squeezing the air out of your lungs. I told him to spare you."

"If you expect me to say 'thank you,' you won't hear it from me anytime."

"It wasn't my intention to protect you anyways."

Adora lowered her brows. "Because you don't care about anyone except yourself. You repeated Shadow Weaver's abusive behavior. You're both manipulative and cruel."

Catra's muscles tensed at the mention of the bitter hag. "You were her favorite. Shadow Weaver loved you and hated me. You broke your promise to me and ran off with the princesses."

"I chose to leave the Horde. You stayed behind," Adora said. "The promises we made to each other as kids didn't mean anything to you. Whenever I did something you didn't like, you attacked me."

"You abandoned me."

"Go away!"

Catra made her way to an adjacent hallway, fuming as she found a window and sat on the ledge. Here she was, a former force captain, heeding the orders of a galactic warlord. She missed leading an army and ordering troops around. If Adora hadn't activated the superweapon, neither woman would be here. She stared out the window, observing the spaceships. Many of them were gliding toward Etheria. Prime's soldiers were probably fighting the Rebellion by now. She rested her head against the glass.

Memories of Catra's life in the Etherian Horde surfaced, flooding her brain. At first, she recalled snippets of her childhood. Training with Adora and their old friends, receiving harsh punishments, arguing with her adoptive sister over favoritism, and many more. Then came the day Adora was promoted to Force Captain. And everything else that followed. Their fights on the battlefield, tricking her with a corrupted disk, setting off the portal, and their confrontation at an outpost.

Catra thought of Scorpia. The taller woman saw her as a friend, perhaps something more. She didn't care about their friendship, despite Scorpia helping her a few times. The walls around her heart served a purpose. Acting cold had worked in her favor. Several people had hurt her in the past. Why should she be vulnerable again? What good was there in friendships? Shadow Weaver, a mother figure to her and Adora, was an abusive woman. The old witch once tricked Catra into letting her flee. Scorpia also left the Horde after calling the magicat a bad friend. Double Trouble betrayed the Horde. Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio were gone, too.

"You're a bad friend."

"You made your choice. Now live with it!"

Catra shook her head as she slipped off the ledge. There was no way she would let the words of former friends get to her. They never cared about her. She balled her hands into fists, claws digging into her palms as she stormed to the nearest door. A clone stepped in front of her, blocking her from proceeding.

"Cut the crap!" Catra demanded.

"This area is off-limits," the clone replied.

"Oh, come on!" Catra rolled her eyes. "Why won't you leave me alone?"

"Little sister, leave the area."

"Fine."

Catra raced to an intersection, hurrying past clones and doors. No matter how fast she was, the clones wouldn't stop stalking her. She wasn't the one behind the force field, so why were they following her around? A clone called her "little sister," but she didn't catch the rest of the sentence. Apparently the clones were one big family who referred to "guests" as little siblings.

Glimmer and the Princess Alliance had set up camp after recharging her powers. They couldn't remain at Bright Moon Castle due to the invasion. It had been three days since Adora's disappearance. According to reports, the blonde was nowhere to be found. Because of that, she concluded that the Galactic Horde captured Adora. She wished she had never set off the Heart of Etheria. If she had listened, Adora would still be safe and sound.

Glimmer entered the main tent and sat with the princesses. Entrapta and Scorpia were in another tent. Shadow Weaver was in a tent made for prisoners. As for Double Trouble, Glimmer had no idea where they went. She wasn't too worried about their location, as they had been the reason behind the strain in her friendship with Adora.

"How are we going to bring Adora back?" Perfuma asked. "We can't count on Entrapta to help us. She attacked us with her creations."

Bow placed a hand on Perfuma's shoulder. "We should give Entrapta a chance."

"Bow, you heard me."

Mermista sighed as she rested her elbows on the table. "Entrapta will betray us the moment she sees more Horde technology. There's gotta be a way to rescue Adora without relying on the geeky princess for assistance."

Frosta frowned. "Are we gonna sit in here the whole time? I want to punch some robots with my ice fists."

Glimmer stood. "We're still figuring out the rescue mission. Adora's up there waiting for us. She needs us. I could ask Entrapta to work on Mara's ship. The rest of you could guard the camp after the meeting ends."

Glimmer and her friends continued talking until the meeting was over. They discussed multiple ideas and strategies. There could be a chance that they would fall short in their efforts to rescue Adora.

Whoever was holding Adora hostage, they could be doing awful things to the blonde. She stepped outside and scrutinized the sky. Then, she summoned her staff. Where were her enemies holding Adora? How far away was the hero? She thought of their recent arguments. Would they ever repair their friendship? Or would things be different? She knew her actions endangered Adora. Would the hero ever forgive her?

"Hello," a masculine voice said, drawing Glimmer's attention to her father.

"Hi," Glimmer replied. At least she could talk to her father.

"So, your friend's kidnapped?"

"Yeah. Adora is in captivity because of my choice to use the Heart of Etheria. Things got worse, and I don't know where she is. I've been a bad queen and an awful friend."

Micah shook his head. "You're not a bad queen. I'm sure your mother would be proud. You're protecting innocent civilians from the clones and the bots."

"Yeah, right. I'm not good at protecting others. I let Adora get taken," Glimmer said.

"Don't be hard on yourself. I have a feeling you'll see Adora again."

"You were gone for years. Had you ever felt like giving up at some point?"

"No. I didn't stop hoping."

Glimmer gazed at the ground. "All I did was ruin things. I tried to be a hero, like Adora had been. Perhaps I should have stayed out of the fight. Only someone weak and ineffective would mess things up."

Micah placed a finger under Glimmer's chin, drawing her gaze to his eyes. "Your friend told me you're the bravest person she knew."

Did Adora seriously say that Glimmer was the bravest person ever? The same queen who hurt her feelings and went behind her back? Sure, Glimmer did a few things someone would consider courageous, such as knocking Shadow Weaver out despite risking a temporal loss of magic. Somehow, the word didn't seem to apply to her. It fitted Adora more.

Micah walked along the dirt path and approached Castaspella. Glimmer glanced at the magical barrier shielding the camp. The sorcerers were busy repairing cracks and holes. She entered a nearby tent. Entrapta and Scorpia were in the middle of a conversation when Glimmer approached.

"Hi," Entrapta said.

"Entrapta, you will work on Mara's ship," Glimmer replied.

"Do I get to go into space?" Entrapta asked, grinning. "It's gonna be exciting!"

"Entrapta, we're going into space to bring Adora back, not fool around."

Entrapta nodded. "Got it. The upgrade could take a few days, as I have to ensure the ship works correctly."

Glimmer led Entrapta outside. "It better be done as soon as possible. We don't want to be too late to save Adora."

"I'll do my best."

As they walked past the tents, Glimmer peeked at the sorcerers. They seemed tired from expending magical energy. Hopefully the barrier would last several more days. If it would last longer, it would give Entrapta enough time. However, if the entire barrier

shattered, and their enemies invaded the camp, they would have to go somewhere, delaying the ship's upgrades.

A delay could mean being too late to save Adora. Glimmer followed Entrapta to the ship, then stood by the tent flap. The geeky princess began working on the vessel.

"Space has a lot of dangers and variables. Crushing pressure, freezing temperatures, vaporization-" Entrapta began.

"It's not gonna hinder us from rescuing Adora," Glimmer interrupted. "Bow, Adora, and I faced danger countless times."

"I'll determine Adora's precise location… soon… I'll have to track down the signal."

"Are you sure you can go out there and risk your life tracking down a signal?"

"Of course."

Glimmer sighed. "Something could go wrong. What will you do if the clones see you?"

Entrapta pulled down her metal mask, obscuring her face. "Don't worry. Someone's gonna be there to keep me safe."

"In that case, I could accompany you. The other princesses could join us."

"They don't like me. And they won't understand me. My mind works differently than theirs. Scorpia and Hordak were one of the few individuals willing to befriend me."

Glimmer cleared her throat. "Did you just mention Hordak? He's evil. Why do you still see him as a friend?"

Entrapta yanked a screwdriver from the toolbox. "He's kind to me."

"You were on the Horde's side back then."

"Catra manipulated me into joining. She used me. Hordak, on the other hand-"

"Entrapta, there isn't any good in him. His army killed a lot of people, destroyed towns, and ruined kingdoms. They captured Adora when she was a baby."

Entrapta paused before pushing her mask toward the top of her head. "Horde Prime banished Hordak because he saw him as defective. Hordak was a clone. Horde Prime considered him flawed. They once conquered planets together."

Glimmer scowled. "Even if Hordak did have it rough, it didn't excuse all the crimes he had committed. He's not a good person. For now, focus on upgrading Mara's ship. I'll help the princesses guard the camp."

The Escape Attempt

Chapter Summary

Adora attempts to escape.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The clones escorted Adora and Catra to the dining room. Horde Prime sat in a chair by the monitors. Adora had memorized part of the ship's layout. She needed to know where to go. And if she had to do it by herself, so be it. But Catra and the clones would chase her. She would have to be sneaky. The blonde and the magicat occupied a pair of seats. Adora glared at Horde Prime. In response, he flashed a serene smile. His creepy eyes scanned her body language.

"Are you enjoying your stay?" Horde Prime asked.

"You're holding me hostage," Adora pointed out. "So, how am I a guest? I'm a prisoner. Catra's allowed to go anywhere."

"My brothers are serving you a meal. Perhaps it'll improve your mood."

The clones pushed a plate of gelatin toward Adora. They gave the same serving to Catra. Adora stuck her fork into the gelatin and brought it to her mouth. The food held no flavor. She missed the meals she had during her time on Etheria.

"Ah, enjoyable, yes? It's a delicacy from a distant world similar to Etheria. This dish is rare, as that world no longer exists," Horde Prime said.

The fork slipped from Adora's hand, clattering against the plate. An uncomfortable feeling settled in her stomach, and she lost her appetite. Of course Horde Prime was planning to destroy Etheria.

The notion of losing her friends and her home disturbed her. She wanted to leave this place and help the Rebellion defend Etheria. Yet the clones were guarding the door. She was outnumbered. Without the Sword of Protection, she wouldn't stand a chance. And she was unable to awaken the weapon inside her. How long would it be dormant?

The monitors flashed to life, displaying a burning camp. Innocent people raced back and forth, screaming. Bow and the Princess Alliance were fighting their enemies. Glimmer unleashed a barrage of spells at every bot and clone. Adora wasn't there to help them. She wasn't there to be Glimmer's hero. How would she keep Etheria safe if she remained in captivity?

"Royalty. A queen, unless I'm mistaken. She means something to you," Horde Prime said. "You're fond of her, aren't you? I can see it in your eyes. I also detect worry in your expression."

Adora relaxed her facial muscles, hoping to seem calm despite the emotions rising within her. Any further indication of how she felt, and Horde Prime would latch on. He could order his cronies to do something awful. It wouldn't be far-fetched, considering. She clasped her hands together and took in deep breaths. Her heartbeat slowed down, albeit briefly. A familiar scream interrupted her thoughts. Someone had gotten hurt.

"Don't hurt Glimmer!" Adora said as she shot up. Her gaze landed on the image of Glimmer on the ground. The sight of the queen's bleeding leg sickened her. "She means everything to me!"

"I'll spare her for now," Horde Prime said.

Adora sat, unable to say another word. Why did Prime say 'for the time being?' Did he want his army to harm those she cared about? She peeked at Catra, who remained silent the entire time. The magicat didn't take long to finish eating. Eventually, Catra looked up.

"What?" Catra asked. "I didn't tell Prime to ambush your friends."

"You told him about the superweapon," Adora said.

"So?"

Before Adora could respond, the clones escorted her to her cell. Once again, they locked her up. She reclined on the cot. The isolation was awful, as she couldn't speak to someone who genuinely cared about her. As much as she wanted to cry, no tears came. All she could do was stare at the ceiling. Time dragged on, and sleepiness washed over her. She drifted into the realm of sleep. Disturbing images flashed in her mind's eye. Tossing and turning, she struggled to keep the nightmares at bay.

…

Adora raced through a battlefield, panting. Thunder roared in the gray sky as she glanced in every direction. Clones and bots tortured innocent people and Rebellion soldiers. Her fingers brushed her forearm, yet the golden brace was absent. Where was the Sword of Protection? How would she transform without it? Pained screams drilled into her ears as her gaze followed the sound. What she saw horrified her. Pools of blood surrounded each member of the Princess Alliance. Mermista, Perfuma, Frosta, and Glimmer. Bow was comatose, too.

"No! I failed you guys!" Adora shouted, sobbing as she raced to Glimmer's side. "I'm sorry I couldn't be there. I couldn't be the hero."

Adora blinked; the scenery transitioned to a field of white and green. There was no sign of plant life, no indication of a friend's presence. She was alone. No one else was here. Eerie whispers penetrated the silence. A step forward, and her foot met an object. She turned her attention to her feet. There was nothing here. Did she imagine things?

"Adora… why did you fail us?"

Adora looked up. Glimmer wore an empty expression. Something wasn't right. Bow and their friends materialized, wearing similar

expressions. What could Adora do to make it up to them? It was obvious. She disappointed everyone. She opened her mouth to speak, and no words came out. Her friends advanced, all of them balling their fists into angry cannonballs.

"Your best isn't good enough!" Glimmer shouted.

The rest of the words blended together as everyone spoke in unison. Adora fell to her knees and covered her ears. She began sobbing. It didn't take long for the voices to fade to silence. Did they leave? It wouldn't surprise her if all her friends abandoned her. A single voice told her otherwise. The speaker was Glimmer. She couldn't see her face, but she could hear disappointment in the queen's words.

"I shouldn't have expected anything good from you. She-Ra ruined everything."

…

Adora sat up, hyperventilating. The blonde buried her face in her trembling hands. Hot tears stained her cheeks. Was the dream telling her something? Or was it from her worries? She couldn't be sure. Other than what she saw on the monitors, she had no idea what happened next. Did Bow or one of the princesses bandage Glimmer's wound? Did they find a better hideout? How bad would the invasion become? Would Prime or his cronies abduct more people? She swung her legs over the cot and strode to the force field. Since she couldn't see the hallway, she could eavesdrop on conversations.

Adora pressed the side of her head against the barrier. She waited for someone to speak. Perhaps there was news about Etheria's situation. Within minutes, two individuals began talking. One of them must be Catra. What was the magicat doing near her cell? Was the brunette hoping to initiate another conversation?

"Hordak, this is getting old," Catra said.

"Catra, don't give me a name," Hordak replied.

"You know me, then? Here's a clue. You're mad because Entrapta betrayed you."

"Entrapta…" A pause hung in the air. "Little sister, don't talk to the weapon."

They didn't say anything else. Not even a word about Etheria. Footsteps walked in opposite directions. One to the left. The other, to the right. Adora returned to the cot and sat. She hated being a prisoner and the loneliness that came with it. Adora missed her friends, especially Glimmer. She missed Swift Wind. There might never be another chance to go to a festival or a party.

Adora glanced at the chair. An idea formed in her mind. If one of the chair legs were loose, she could use it as a makeshift weapon and flee. No, something could go wrong. The clones could catch her, and she would never go home.

You can let it paralyze you… or you can roll with it.

Didn't Adora hear those words before? Wasn't She-Ra the reason for bad things happening? She rose to her height, approached the chair, and jiggled each leg. One of them was loose. She yanked it out. *Perfect.* All she could do was wait for the next meal time. A clone could enter the cell, and she would trick them into letting her escape. Subtle footsteps moved closer to the barrier. Adora put the chair leg back where it belonged. No need to arouse suspicion. Someone could be watching her closely. For a brief moment, a silhouette materialized on the barrier. It appeared to be a clone.

Adora waited for the clone to do something. Instead of the force field vanishing, the footsteps walked away. The silhouette was gone. Was it an unspoken way of warning her against escaping?

Catra followed a clone to the "purification" chamber. Near the green pool, she could see Hordak kneeling before Horde Prime. A chill penetrated the air as she rubbed her arms. Dozens of clones

observed the scene from the shadows. She smoothed the fur on her tail, took a deep breath, and kept an eye on the galactic warlord.

"You spoke to our little sister, did you not?" Horde Prime asked.

"She gave me a name," Hordak replied.

A pair of clones shoved Hordak into the water as the chanting began. Horde Prime grinned at Catra, and she squared her shoulders. A scream of agony echoed off the walls. Electricity sparked all around the pool and zapped Hordak. Would she suffer the same fate?

"You gave our little brother a name," Horde Prime said.

Catra nodded. "I did. We knew each other."

"He doesn't need a name. And why do you continue visiting She-Ra's cell?"

"I was making sure she doesn't leave."

"You were? Our brothers are watching her. They don't require your assistance. You told me there were other princesses, correct? I intend to use the superweapon. However, She-Ra's defiance stands in the way of my goal."

"We could go to Etheria and activate the superweapon. Each princess is connected to a runestone."

Horde Prime rested his forearms behind his back. "We'll do it as soon as the weapon agrees to cooperate. Otherwise, my brothers will use a prototype on her."

"Prototype?" Catra asked.

"You'll see."

Catra entered the hallway, wondering what the warlord meant by 'prototype.' She couldn't imagine Adora cooperating. The blonde made it clear that she would refuse to help. Catra strode into a dark corridor and leaned against the metal wall. She wasn't concerned about what could happen to Adora. Rising to the top was more important. The hero could rot in prison for all she cared. A clone approached her.

"Little sister, you can't be in here," the clone said.

"Buzz off," Catra replied as she stormed into a well-lit hallway.

Catra couldn't get over how condescending the clones sounded. Their leader, Horde Prime, was arrogant. As long as she was of value to Prime, she had a place in this world. She would work her way up. The problem was that she needed to come up with something soon. It wouldn't be easy to manipulate the galactic warlord. Hordak, on the other hand, was easy to handle. She would have to be clever.

Unaware of where she was going, Catra bumped into Horde Prime. Was he stalking her, too? She stepped back, maintaining eye contact. Unlike Hordak and Shadow Weaver, this creep didn't yell at her. His lack of a reaction made him intimidating. Maybe he was hiding his anger.

"I received a report of you trespassing in forbidden areas," Horde Prime said, a subtle growl seeping into his tone. "I do not tolerate disobedience. You would be wise to listen."

"No. *You* listen! You can't use the superweapon without my help. We will work together," Catra replied.

Horde Prime pressed his lips into a thin line. "Why should we?"

"I had been close to conquering Etheria! I know how to fight the Princess Alliance!"

Catra hated that her plan relied on Prime's amount of cooperativeness. If he couldn't take her words into consideration,

she might come up with a new strategy. Ten excruciating minutes passed as Horde Prime remained silent. What he said next satisfied her on some level.

"Very well," Horde Prime said. "Depart from my sight while I consider your words."

Catra walked to another hallway and glimpsed a window. Her plan could work in the end. She hopped onto the sill and gazed at the specks of light in the blackness. Succeeding never came without a cost. And someday, if possible, she could control the Galactic Horde. An emptiness grew within her heart. No. It'll be worth it. *No one will hurt me ever again,* she told herself.

You drive them away, wildcat.

Catra shook her head. She couldn't go soft. She couldn't cave into her loneliness. Friendships were for weaklings. An image of Scorpia surfaced in her mind. Not again. Why couldn't she stop thinking about the people who left her? A memory of their discussion in the Crimson Waste replayed in her mind. The scorpioni must have hoped for her to stay in the Crimson Waste. If the magicat had said yes, would things be different? No portal and no Galactic Horde?

It wouldn't have mattered anyways. Catra ran her fingers through her thick hair. Was she satisfied? Or did she leave herself wanting more of something? Footsteps moved past her. Another clone. Were Catra and Adora the only non-clones on the Velvet Glove? It seemed that way to her. Horde Prime would hate it if both women communicated. She could figure out the perfect excuse to talk to Adora, and he would still say no.

Catra wouldn't apologize to Adora. She saw no reason to do so. Still, they grew up together. They were sisters. Sighing, she slipped off the sill and landed on her feet. They would never go back to the way they once were. And perhaps it was a good thing.

Five days passed as Glimmer waited in the infirmary tent for her injury to heal. It wasn't as painful as before. Entrapta, Scorpia, and the other princesses had gone to a spire to track down a signal yesterday. It wasn't part of Glimmer's original plan, but it was fine. As she once told Adora, she would roll with it. Mara's ship was ready anyways. Bow entered the tent.

"So, how's the injury?" Bow asked.

"It's getting better. We must rescue Adora," Glimmer replied.

"I know we do. You need to be careful when fighting."

Glimmer crossed her arms. "Careful? Adora's in danger. Without the Sword of Protection, she can't defend herself. We can't idle here and somehow expect her to come home safely. I'd do anything to make sure she was safe. Besides, did Entrapta succeed in tracking down the signal?"

"Yes, she did. We should be able to save Adora soon," Bow said.

"Good."

"You miss Adora, don't you?"

"Of course."

Glimmer allowed the memories to come. Meeting Adora, watching her save Thaymor, protecting each other, relaxing in the Steam Grotto, dancing at Princess Prom (although brief), fighting the Horde together, sparring sessions, and many more. The delight in the blonde's baby blue eyes when trying festival food for the first time. The times when they cuddled beneath the covers. Then, the bad moments took center stage in her mind. Bickering with Adora, using her as a decoy, and blaming her for Angella's death. The last time they spoke, they argued before Adora went to Beast Island.

Glimmer had been reckless by teleporting to the Fright Zone and setting off the Heart of Etheria. It was good that Bow took her out

of the headquarters. On the same night, they had searched for Adora in the Whispering Woods and Bright Moon Castle. Shadow Weaver had mentioned the blonde's arrival at the castle. According to the old sorceress, it was right after Glimmer left. If she had stayed behind, she would have talked to her friend.

Bow left the tent. Glimmer turned her attention to the leather bag by the crate. She had taken some of Adora's belongings. A clean set of clothes and a journal. At least they would make her feel close to the blonde. She strode toward the bag, took out the journal, and plopped onto a nearby chair. There was a pencil attached to the book.

Glimmer began reading the entries. As the queen read the words, she imagined Adora talking. Within an hour or so, she reached the heartbreaking parts. They told her how Adora felt about the arguments. She thought of the tears in the blonde's eyes. Angella's sacrifice wasn't Adora's fault. Yet Glimmer blurted out those hurtful words. She shut the book and stashed it in the bag. How many times had she dreamed about their strained friendship? She wished she could take those words back. But she couldn't. Her recent actions were why Adora turned to the journal for comfort.

A clone led Adora to a trophy room, where Horde Prime waited. Multiple shelves displayed weapons and artifacts. She could see the monitors. The galactic warlord smiled as usual. She knew he wasn't polite. What was the purpose of his polite facade? The clone shoved her toward the monitors. Glancing over her shoulder, she scowled at her nameless enemy. The screens flashed to life, revealing various locations in Etheria. Some towns were overrun by Prime's army. Clones and bots captured their terrified victims. A village was on fire. Adora placed her palm on the screen.

"The weapon misses her home, doesn't she?" Horde Prime said.

"I'm not a weapon," Adora replied. "So stop referring to me as one. I won't let you get away with destroying Etheria. It's my

home. I broke the sword to disable the Heart of Etheria. And you saw an opportunity to take over. You abducted me. I won't be a pawn in your wicked plan to conquer the planet."

"Unless you join my army, you won't return to your planet. A spy informed me of you and the queen arguing. She won't welcome you back after everything. You are better off as a soldier for my army."

Adora snatched a sword from the shelf and swung the blade at Horde Prime. He caught her wrist and launched his free hand at her neck. When would Prime get the message? And why was he desperate to use her? There was no way she would give him what he wanted. Prime tightened his grip on her neck and her wrist. Rage burned in his eyes, and time seemed to crawl. She dropped the sword due to the pressure on her wrist.

Horde Prime released Adora's neck. "Are you done resisting me?"

Adora rubbed her neck, panting. If Prime had choked her any longer, she would have passed out. The towering warlord was furious. His polite facade had melted away. Her pulse raced, and her shoulders tensed. He would take her by surprise if she reached for the sword. Horde Prime would be swift to block her punches and kicks.

"Brothers, take She-Ra to her guest room," Horde Prime said. "Little sister, there will be *consequences* for forcing my hand."

The clones escorted Adora to her so-called 'guest room.' She was alone again. The way Prime emphasized the word 'consequences,' it sent a chill up and down her spine. Would he force her against her will? She held no desire to know. If she didn't escape, he would hurt her. And he would destroy Etheria. Adora plopped onto the cot and waited for a clone to enter. Tapping her foot, she observed the barrier. She was ready to get out of here.

Adora folded her hands in her lap and chewed her bottom lip. How would she pass the time if she had nothing to do? Other

than messing with chair legs, eavesdropping on guards, and losing herself in her thoughts... The only alternative was to talk to Catra, something she would hate doing. She nibbled her nails, listening for footsteps. Soon, a guard approached the barrier. She grabbed the chair leg, hurried forward, and stood by the green shield, hidden from view. A clone placed a tray on the table. Now was her chance to strike.

Adora swung the chair leg at the clone's head, knocking him forward. Before the clone could react, she snatched the fork from the tray and jammed it into the green hole in his neck. A current of electricity snaked up the fork, barely shocking her as she let go. Heart thrashing against her ribs, she fled the cell and ran. Footsteps and voices wafted into her ears. She ducked behind a pillar, shaking. *You can do this,* she told herself. However, the self-talk didn't bring her any comfort. She peeked out from her hiding spot. The coast was clear.

Adora ran again, moving as fast as possible. She found an intersection. One corridor was dark, and the other was well-lit. What if she went the wrong way? A clone emerged from the dark hallway, advancing. She evaded a punch and sidestepped, giving herself room to land a hit. Adrenaline pumped through her veins as she plunged the chair leg into his neck. She yanked it out and proceeded into the well-lit hallway. More clones appeared, pursuing her. Her lungs burned as she jumped behind a wall of metal crates.

Adora held out her hand as if holding a sword. "For the honor of Grayskull." To her disappointment, she didn't transform. "Crap." She stormed into an adjacent room.

Hundreds of large tubes dotted the walls. Many of them were empty, except for one. The dark hair and clothes made him stand out from the other clones. Hordak floated in the tube, unconscious. Swallowing a hard lump in her throat, Adora darted into the hallway. Her plan wasn't working well, and she better be quick. Escaping was her top priority. She couldn't stay on the Velvet Glove any longer.

Adora looked over her shoulder, then forward. She made her way to a docking bay. She could take one of the ships. Countless scenarios flashed through her mind, none of them good. What if she didn't make it out alive? What if the clones ambushed her? Get moving, *she urged herself.* Etheria needs *She-Ra.* A shout froze her in her tracks.

"Hey!"

Adora didn't have to look to know who was speaking. Whirling around, she saw Catra standing by the archway. The magicat lunged at Adora. Adora jumped to the side. She wasn't about to give up on fleeing the Velvet Glove.

"You don't have She-Ra. And chair legs aren't swords!" Catra spat as she brandished her whip. "Prime's gonna be pissed!"

The whip enveloped the chair leg and wrenched it from Adora's hand. She widened her stance and held up her fists. Catra sprung at Adora, claws extended. Adora rammed her shoulder into Catra's abdomen, knocking her to the floor. The magicat scratched Adora's neck, just above the collarbone. Despite the claws not going deep, it still stung. Adora pounded Catra across her face.

"That's for all the pain you put me through!" Adora yelled.

Adora continued punching Catra, too furious to register the sound of footsteps. A clone pulled her backward, both arms restraining her. She struggled to break free, but her captor was too strong. Horde Prime accompanied the clones. Catra stood. A bruise had formed on the magicat's jaw.

"I figured you would attempt to escape. You won't have a choice, little sister," Horde Prime said. "Brothers, take her to the purification chamber."

Within seconds, the clones handcuffed Adora and dragged her into a corridor. Sweat moistened her forehead as she attempted to wriggle free. Prime and his cronies would definitely force her against her will. She didn't consent to any of this. The blonde

wouldn't agree to whatever they would do to her. Now would be the perfect moment for her dormant power to awaken. Yet it didn't come to her. Sitting around until a friend rescued her shouldn't be an option. Besides, her friends were busy battling the Galactic Horde. It was unlikely for any of them to storm the Velvet Glove and bust her out.

The clones shoved Adora into a large chamber. She gawked at the green pool. Thousands of green eyes stared at her. Panic overwhelmed her as she felt herself being pushed toward the water. If she had been any quicker, she would have boarded one of the ships in the docking bay and traveled to Etheria.

"Cast out the shadows! Cast out the shadows!" The clones chanted.

Adora stomped on her captor's foot. "Let me go!"

The clone didn't budge. Something sharp and metallic pricked Adora's neck. What were they doing? Her mind raced with ideas on how to flee. None of them were logical. Her captors threw her into the pool. The icy water submerged her as she held her breath. Every memory of her life played out. Memories of Glimmer surfaced. Meeting her, befriending each other, going on missions, hugging her, and their conversations during the queen's coronation. She had promised to take care of her. And she failed. Something was pulling them out of Adora as the murky pool electrocuted her.

The air burst from her lungs as a hand yanked Adora out. Someone placed her on the ground. Wheezing, she glimpsed the water. She was no longer drowning. Horde Prime loomed over her, standing tall. His eyes glowed green. She was unaware of hers doing the same.

"How do you feel now, little sister?" Horde Prime asked.

Adora found it hard to explain this sense of peace. There was no worry about disappointing anyone, and no fear of failing those she

was supposed to protect. Blissfulness rested in her entire body. Was it how people felt if they had nothing to be afraid of?

"Does it feel nice?" Horde Prime added.

Adora nodded. A tiny part of her told her to act. Instead, she followed Horde Prime wherever he guided her. She could focus on being the hero Horde Prime needed. She wouldn't heed the demands of some so-called 'friends' who caused her pain. Upon seeing Catra, anger flooded her heart. As soon as the emotion came, it dissipated.

"You seem different," Catra said.

"You brought me misery. Horde Prime brought me into the light and gave me peace," Adora said in a voice that wasn't hers.

Chapter End Notes

Comments/Kudos appreciated 🥲

Chipped

Catra was surprised at how different Adora behaved. And it hadn't taken long for the blonde's appearance to change. Instead of the signature jacket, pants, and boots, her sister wore a white robe with the gray Horde emblem on the front. Adora's ponytail no longer had its 'poof' on her head. Every hair remained in place, with no strand sticking out. The pool and the prototype had taken the fight out of her. Adora was compliant and calm. No, peaceful. Horde Prime mentioned taking Adora to Etheria and using her to capture the princesses. Catra's jaw ached, and she rubbed her injury. She-Ra would have been a lot more brutal. A clone approached the magicat and told her to see Horde Prime in the throne room.

Catra went to the throne room. A part of her expected to see Adora kneeling. The blonde wasn't here. Where did she go? *Don't think about it, Catra. You don't owe Adora anything,* she told herself. Horde Prime rose from his throne, smiling. She couldn't tell what his current emotional state was. Was he angry? Deep in thought? Catra descended to one knee and bowed her head.

"Greetings, Lord Prime," Catra said.

"Greetings, little sister," Horde Prime replied. "You have done well in catching She-Ra. You were close to letting her flee. As a result, our brothers had to intervene. She was a fool, attacking one of them during her meal time. I intend to tap into the power she carries within her. A brother informed me of the Etherian rebels' plan to launch a ship into space. Do you know what it is?"

Catra figured Prime was talking about the ship with the weird hologram. "It's an old vessel. I led a gang to it. Adora, Perfuma, and Bow stole it. Speaking of Perfuma, she's one of the princesses. She's connected to a runestone."

"Ah. I've looked into the weapon's memories. A water princess, an ice princess, the plant princess, and the queen."

Catra made eye contact. "Mermista's element is water, and Frosta's element is ice. Anyways, let's get back on topic. Has the army thwarted the Rebels?"

The corners of Prime's mouth turned downward in a grimace. "The Rebels have refused to surrender. They have chosen to stay in the darkness. Their queen is leading the attack. She once asked one of our brothers about She-Ra's location."

"Sounds like Sparkles wants to find Adora."

"Once I awaken the warrior within the weapon, we will travel to Etheria. You're dismissed. I'll give you a task when we're in Etheria."

Catra left the throne room. Horde Prime was making it harder for her to rise to the top. Guess he was too intelligent to let anyone manipulate him. She was only valuable as long as she obeyed him. If she stepped out of line, he might use the prototype on her or discard her. A can rolled into the hallway, and she heard a squeak. Her mind drifted to the time she saw a mouse in the Horde headquarters. For a minute, she let the memory play out. Catra and Adora had chased the mouse, only for an older soldier to catch it. Shadow Weaver had lectured them after that. Growling, Catra let the memory fade.

It was hard to remember how Catra winded up in the Fright Zone all those years ago. Her origin wasn't significant to her, though. Her gaze followed the sound. A small figure emerged. *Imp?* How did he get on the ship? Was he abducted along with Catra, Adora, and Hordak? She picked him up. Imp could be feeling abandoned. Footsteps echoed behind them, and she spun, preparing to explain Imp's presence. However, instead of Horde Prime or one of his clones, Hordak stood before her. His eyes flickered, turning from green to red.

"Catra… I've temporarily cut myself off. Prime won't hear us," Hordak said.

"I have no interest in chatting," Catra replied. "You can have Imp."

"He's not safe here. And I should have killed you. Can we talk?"

"Fine. What is there to discuss?"

"Is Horde Prime right? Are the Rebels planning to launch the ship? Is She-Ra chipped?"

Catra's ears flattened against her head. "Yes. And yes."

Hordak narrowed his eyes. "Horde Prime will dispose of She-Ra if he no longer finds her useful. And someone could have upgraded the ship. You know who."

"Who? Entrapta? She's on Beast Island. You'll never see her again. She's a traitor!"

"She's with the Rebellion. And she has upgraded the ship. Horde Prime will capture her if she comes here."

Catra bared her fangs. "I don't care. You brought him to Etheria. Isn't it what you wanted?"

Hordak opened his mouth, then pressed his lips together. Imp jumped out of Catra's arms and sprung toward him. His eyes reverted to a green void. Catra walked past them, muttering to herself. Hordak couldn't answer one question. He still liked Entrapta, despite what Catra told him. And why did he care about what could happen to Adora? Did he forget the blonde's betrayal?

Catra arrived at one section of the Velvet Glove, where Horde Prime held the prisoners. More had winded up on the vessel earlier. They called themselves the Star Siblings. *Serves them right,* Catra mused. She approached Adora's cell, slid her palm along the barrier, and peered into the room. The blonde remained unconscious. Adora's chest rose and fell. Her eyebrows hiked up and down in a swift motion. A soft whimper escaped Adora's lips. Upon hearing footsteps, Catra backed away.

"Don't disturb the weapon, little sister," a clone said.

Catra gave a brief nod before wandering to an intersection. As much as she tried to ignore it, loneliness gripped her heart. She walked to a window, as usual. And stared into the blackness. There was no way she would allow herself to make amends with those who left her. Being caring once got her in trouble.

Do you know what happened to me after you escaped? Do you even care?

Catra would never forget the hatred in Shadow Weaver's eyes. She should have sent the old witch to Beast Island. For a moment, she wondered what it would be like to be raised by someone loving. Would she have turned out differently? Sighing, she gazed at her reflection in the glass. She didn't see a Force Captain. In her reflection's place stood an isolated magicat who struggled to rise to the top. A life in the Horde hardened her. She had always been at someone else's mercy, even on the Velvet Glove. Sure, Horde Prime didn't physically attack her. He didn't shout at her.

Yet Catra carried a lingering fear of infuriating Horde Prime. She had seen what he did to Hordak, and how he responded to Adora fleeing. Was Horde Prime waiting for Catra to anger him?

Adora floated in midair, unaware of her current location. Whispers penetrated the silence as she opened her eyes. Instead of a sky or a ceiling, a sea of green stretched above her. She landed on her feet. The ground and walls were the same color. She gasped at the sensation of icy hands touching her face. No one was here. For all she knew, someone was sitting next to her in the waking world. Shivers vibrated all over her body. Whatever this place was, it creeped her out. The area transitioned into her cell. Violet eyes peered through the barrier.

Adora's heart skipped a beat. Would her friends rescue her? The green void disappeared, revealing Glimmer. Bow accompanied the

queen. Adora rushed closer, feeling overjoyed at the possibility of going home. She couldn't wait to get out of here.

"Guys! You came!" Adora exclaimed. "I missed you so much!"

"Where's the sword?" Glimmer asked.

"I broke it." Adora could see the disappointment in the queen's eyes. "I can no longer transform into She-Ra."

"We needed She-Ra. Now Etheria's doomed. We came for She-Ra, not Adora."

Glimmer and Bow faded. Adora pounded the barrier with both fists, sobbing. It was all her fault. The green shield vanished, and she stepped out. She might have to save herself. A hero wouldn't rely on others to rescue them. She began running. However, her movements were slow. Eventually, she stumbled into a barren field. How did she get here? Familiar silhouettes surrounded her. A cacophony of words pierced her ears.

"They expected you to be perfect and blamed you for everything. They left you with physical and emotional scars. Pain and grief clouded your mind. Horde Prime will never hurt you… You are safe with him, She-Ra. You are a hero, no matter what anyone tells you…"

…

Adora's power awakened within her body as she opened her eyes. She transformed into She-Ra. Instead of white and gold, she wore a green and gray uniform. Bat wings materialized on her chest. She sat up, then glanced at Horde Prime. The warlord's grin widened. Her mind was hazy. Was her brain not working? Despite the bliss, something was off. She had no idea why. However, there was no reason to worry.

"Your home has been a pain, has it not?" Horde Prime said. "Etherians and their unrealistically high expectations of you. They're demanding, and whenever a problem arises, they rely on

you to fix it. They never do it themselves. You must have grown tired of it. Are you ready to put them in their place? Will you make your mark?"

"Yes, Horde Prime," Adora said.

They strode into the hallway. Horde Prime talked about Etheria, the superweapon, and the Galactic Horde. Adora passed by a window. A familiar planet caught her attention. More ships were approaching Etheria. She was sure the Etherians lost hope by now. Good. Let them feel despair. Those people made a big deal out of their problems, no matter how trivial. The sparkling queen entered her mind. Every argument flashed into her thoughts, including the one over the Heart of Etheria. Being blamed for Angella's death topped it off. There were times when Adora wished she had taken the Sword of Protection. That way, Angella would still be alive.

Adora suppressed the weakness that threatened to surface. Nothing she did ever made her so-called 'friends' happy. Exhaling, the blonde followed Horde Prime to the throne room. She would be in Etheria soon. Catra walked into the throne room. When the magicat noticed Adora, she smirked. Images of their clashes came. The Battle of Bright Moon. Their confrontation in the portal reality. And everything else Catra had done.

"Are you gonna say something?" Catra asked.

"Why do you ask? I answer to Prime, not to you," Adora said.

After a day of battling clones and bots, Glimmer and her friends gathered in the main tent. The plan to go into space didn't work, as the Galactic Horde kept trying to hinder the Princess Alliance. She scrutinized the notes and papers. There were reports of disappearances and chipped individuals. The queen and the archer would have traveled into space by now if their enemies hadn't gotten in the way. Why were their foes doing this? Did they know something the Princess Alliance was unaware of? What if

Horde Prime chipped Adora? The last question replayed in Glimmer's mind.

"They still have Adora," Glimmer said. "And they won't let us use Mara's ship."

"Yeah," Mermista replied. "And Sea Hawk is chipped. I haven't seen him since then. Who else will they take? Without She-Ra, we're hopeless."

"Mermista, they'll stop at nothing to destroy Etheria. And until we get Adora back, we must push forward. We'll do our best to save Etheria."

Perfuma clutched her platinum curls. "It's a disaster. Half the people in Plumeria got chipped. We don't know where Netossa and Spinnerella are."

Frosta leaned back in her chair. "The Galactic Horde attacked my kingdom, too."

Glimmer exhaled audibly. "Things might seem bleak, but we'll win in the end. We won't back down, regardless of what Prime throws at us. Etheria needs us. So does Adora. We'll show him we're not done fighting, and we will never give up. Let's fight for our home." She placed her hand on the center of the table. "Anyone in?"

Perfuma rested a hand on top of Glimmer's. "Yes."

The others joined, agreeing with Perfuma and Glimmer. The queen smiled, and so did her friends. Glimmer would do anything to see Adora again. She missed the blonde's adorable laughter and warm smile. She missed hugging her friend and cuddling with her. If something horrible happened to Adora, Glimmer would never have the chance to tell her how she felt. She had been fond of the warrior ever since the battle in Thaymor.

The Princess Alliance should act soon if they didn't want to lose Adora and Etheria forever. Glimmer strode outside. The sun had finished setting into the horizon. Trees swayed in the breeze. A

magical dome surrounded the camp. She wandered along the path to her tent. It would be nice to talk to Adora, especially after everything. Adora deserved a much-needed apology. Glimmer stepped into the tent and reclined on her makeshift bed. Despite everything the Princess Alliance was doing, it felt as if they didn't make any progress. They didn't come any closer to rescuing Adora and saving the world.

The hours dragged on as Glimmer lost herself in her thoughts. Sleepiness blanketed her body, beckoning her to dreamland. She began tossing and turning. Blurred images materialized in her mind's eye…

…

Glimmer raced through the Whispering Woods, searching the area. A scream penetrated the air. Either someone got hurt, or they got captured. The same person shouted again. It sounded like a cry for help. She ran faster, darting past countless trees. As soon as she reached a clearing, she saw Adora standing by the bush. It didn't make sense. Wasn't the blonde in trouble? She was sure it was Adora who screamed. Her friend gave her a blank stare, blue eyes glistening with tears.

"Why did you yell at me and use the Heart of Etheria?" Adora asked. "Why did you use me as a decoy?"

"Adora, I-" Glimmer started to answer.

"Why didn't you save me?"

As the blonde spoke, a clone approached Adora from behind and grabbed her with both arms. Her eyes widened as she struggled against her captor's grip. Glimmer held up a hand and attempted to cast a spell. However, nothing came. Not even a single spark of magic. The clone carried Adora into the shadows. Glimmer pursued them, stopping at nothing to rescue her friend. The next thing she knew, she reached the edge of the forest. Both

individuals were nowhere to be found. A twig snapped, and she glanced in the direction of the sound.

Adora was alone. And her eyes glowed green. What did Horde Prime's cronies do to her? Glimmer waited for Adora to move. The blonde showed no indication of wanting to fight. Everything went black. All she could see was darkness.

…

Glimmer jolted awake. The queen's eyes took in the outline of furniture as she panted. She was in the tent, not in the Whispering Woods. It was yet another Adora dream. This time, it showed a chipped Adora. Was it a warning? Or the product of her worries? She rested her head on the pillow and rolled to her side. Apparently there was no rest for those who endangered a planet. How would she sleep if the nightmares kept plaguing her? Would they stop if she found Adora and saved Etheria?

Fragments of the nightmare lingered. Glimmer's eyelids grew heavy, but she resisted the pull of sleep. The dream reminded her of what she lost in her desperation to defeat the Etherian Horde. Would she ever rescue Adora from Horde Prime's clutches? She thought about what she could say to her friend.

Morning came. Glimmer made her way to the main tent. Netossa was here, chatting with the princesses. However, Spinnerella was absent. Netossa wore bandages on her upper arm and her leg. The dark-skinned woman seemed upset.

"They chipped Spinny," Netossa said. "I want her back, no matter what it takes."

"How did it happen?" Glimmer asked.

"We were at a party. The guests were acting weird. Their food was stale. Spinny and I tried to leave, but the villagers attempted to trap us. They mentioned Horde Prime giving them peace. We fought our way out and fled to the nearest camp. It was when

Spinnerella called me 'beloved.' Her eyes turned green. That's when I realized she was chipped."

Glimmer nodded as she listened to the story. The princesses discussed raided towns. She knew they should act soon. Freeing villages, un-chipping people, and defending the planet. They could earn small victories, yet Etheria was vulnerable without She-Ra.

"We need to start saving villages from Prime's control," Glimmer said.

After the meeting, Glimmer led Mermista, Perfuma, Netossa, and Bow out of the camp. They would visit Erelandia, one of the villages under Prime's control. Micah, Frosta, and Castaspella would guard the camp. So far, no bot spotted the group. Glimmer didn't see any clones in the vicinity. She kept her eyes peeled for any sign of danger. Hopefully there wouldn't be an ambush.

The group was careful as they walked closer to their destination. They avoided the watchful eyes of clones and bots. Adora would know what to do if the blonde was here. A village came into view. Glimmer spotted two clones guarding the entrance. She and her friends outnumbered them. It shouldn't be too hard to fight their way into the town. Horde flags swayed in the breeze. Summoning her staff and a purple orb, she observed her foes. The duo was scrutinizing the area for anyone who would approach. A few bots hovered in the sky. Glimmer recalled the attack on the Princess Alliance's first camp. There could be a risk of getting hurt, but at least her friends were nearby.

Glimmer unleashed kinetic blasts at the clones, knocking them out. The magic garnered the attention of the bots. Mermista discharged water tendrils at them. The group raced into the village. Everyone in town seemed skittish, trembling whenever they saw Prime's minions. Glimmer and her friends glanced around. Netossa said that they should find Spinnerella. Mermista suggested searching for Sea Hawk. Glimmer couldn't blame them for worrying about their respective partners.

"We'll find them soon," Glimmer said.

A powerful gust of wind almost knocked the group off their feet. Spinnerella floated in the air, staring them down. Netossa flung nets at her wife; Spinnerella deflected them. Perfuma shot large vines toward Spinnerella in an attempt to restrain her. The wind blew the vines away. Glimmer summoned a rune and launched it at Spinnerella, hoping to slow her down. Spinnerella evaded the magic and continued tormenting the group.

"Spinny, stop!" Netossa shouted. "It's me, Netossa! We're here to help you!"

"Beloved, Lord Prime has given me peace. It's time for you to join us," Spinnerella said in a voice that wasn't hers. "Resisting is pointless." She conjured a gale.

The debris ascended into the air, flying in multiple directions. Glimmer summoned a magical shield to protect her friends from the chunks of wood. She waited for Spinnerella to give up. Netossa kept pleading Spinnerella to come back. The wind weakened into a gentle breeze, and Spinnerella's eyes lost the green glow.

"Spinny?" Netossa asked, sounding hopeful.

"Darling?" Spinnerella replied.

Before anyone could say anything else, Spinnerella's blue eyes reverted to sickly green. She disappeared in a swirl of purple wind. It wouldn't be easy to save people who were mind-controlled. The magical shield vanished, and Glimmer looked over to Netossa. She felt awful for her.

"I saw her in there," Netossa said.

"Same," Glimmer replied.

A beam shot past the group. Clones and bots emerged from the alleys. Time to free Erelandia. Glimmer blasted dozens of drones

with purple spheres and runes. Mermista, Netossa, and Perfuma battled the clones. The conflict raged on as the group worked together to crush their enemies. Bystanders stopped to watch the clash. Once it was over, the townspeople cheered. It was a success, albeit a small victory. A few locals thanked Glimmer and the princesses for freeing their town, then asked about She-Ra.

"We'll find her," Glimmer said.

The group left Erelandia, making their way back to the camp. Glimmer kept her head on a swivel, watching for Spinnerella and Sea Hawk. They were nowhere to be found. As for Adora, she had no idea if the blonde had remained on the ship or if Horde Prime was forcing her friend to hurt people. The latter was unpleasant, as Adora would feel guilty for attacking others. A memory of the blonde arose. It had taken place after the disaster in the Northern Reach, when Adora was having nightmares…

…

As Glimmer walked past Adora's bedroom door, she heard soft whimpers. She figured the hero would have nightmares about going berserk. Fury stirred within her. Catra was wrong to smash the corrupted disk against Adora's sword. Catra had been desperate to control the blonde. If the magicat tried to hurt Adora again, Glimmer would wipe that smirk off Catra's face.

Glimmer entered the room and approached a sleeping Adora. Her friend trembled and sobbed. The princess nudged Adora's shoulder as lightly as possible, careful not to scare her. She had seen how Adora had reacted to being awakened.

"Adora, wake up," Glimmer whispered. "Adora!"

Adora sat up, holding up her fists. It didn't take long for her to notice Glimmer's presence. She lowered her hands to her lap. "I hurt you. I was supposed to protect you."

Glimmer guessed Adora was talking about the disaster. "You didn't mean to. If anyone is at fault, it's Catra's."

"I shouldn't have let her touch my sword with the disk." Adora's shoulders slumped as she looked away. "What kind of hero would allow someone like Catra to pull a dirty trick?"

Glimmer took Adora's hands, thumbs caressing the blonde's knuckles. "Don't be hard on yourself. You're not less of a hero because of what happened. You've been doing wonderful as She-Ra. Thanks to you, we have the upper hand in the war. So don't start putting yourself down. The Adora I know wouldn't hurt those she cares about. You're a good person. And you're strong."

Adora made eye contact. "Glim… thanks for the kind words. How's your abdomen, by the way?"

"It's still painful. But I'll heal."

"Are you sure?"

"Of course. Do you want to come to my bed? I'll keep the nightmares away."

"Yes."

Glimmer teleported herself and Adora to her bed, and they slipped beneath the covers. The girls faced each other, limbs tangling as she became aware of their proximity. Adora's eyes fluttered shut. Glimmer tucked a strand behind the hero's ear.

"I won't let Catra do anything to you ever again," Glimmer murmured. "I promise."

…

The memory melted away. Glimmer and the group arrived at the camp. The promise to keep Adora safe lingered in her brain. Glimmer was the same person who let Shadow Weaver have more freedom around Bright Moon Castle. Adora once expressed her concerns regarding what Shadow Weaver could do. The queen hadn't listened to the hero.

Glimmer strode to the meeting tent, made her way to the table, and stared at the map. Erelandia was free for now. Horde Prime was forcing Spinnerella and Sea Hawk to attack innocent people. The dream of a chipped Adora resurfaced in her thoughts. Why couldn't she stop thinking about it?

"Adora…" Glimmer whispered.

Tears leaked from Glimmer's eyes, and she sniffled. She rested her palms against the table, allowing teardrops to stain the papers. The Rebellion kept losing more places to hide. More people had gone missing. Some were dead, and others got chipped. She dug her fingernails into her palms, gritting her teeth. At this point, Horde Prime could be controlling Adora, or he did something much worse. She shoved everything off the table in a fit of rage, sobbing. The queen refused to consider the possibility of either outcome. As far as she knew, no spell could reverse time.

Glimmer wiped her tears, sighing. She needed to be brave for Adora and do whatever she could to help Etheria. She gathered the papers and maps, then dropped them onto the table. Why couldn't all this be just a dream to wake up from?

Glimmer left the tent. Everyone in the camp gazed at something on the horizon. Did something catch their attention? She looked in the same direction. A towering hologram, probably a hundred feet tall, began speaking. He was built like those clones, but sported four eyes and hair tubes. She put two and two together. It was Horde Prime.

"Greetings, Etherians. You must cease your defiance and come to the light," Horde Prime said. "I have the key to the superweapon. Unless you surrender, I will cleanse your home."

A familiar woman accompanied him. It was Adora. And she wore a cold expression. Horde Prime placed a massive hand on Adora's shoulder. The blonde flinched at the touch. Glimmer emitted a growl. Within seconds, Adora seemed to relax. What could the

hero be thinking at the moment? Where was the holographic projection coming from? Glimmer wanted to reach out to Adora and bring her home.

"You depend on She-Ra so much to solve all your problems. I have taken away her pain and grief," Horde Prime said.

The hologram vanished. Glimmer searched for the closest object to take out her anger on. She stormed to a rock and kicked it with enough force to make it fly. It landed a couple feet away.

Together Again

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Upon arrival in Etheria, Catra left the Velvet Glove. The warm sunlight caressed her face, and a breeze whipped through her messy hair. She wasn't here to bask in the beauty of nature. Horde Prime would give her a task. Adora would follow his orders without questioning anything he said. He was still worse than Hordak. Catra walked to a tree and leaned against it, crossing her arms. Imp emerged from the ship, making his way to her. Where was Hordak? Did he not acknowledge Imp's existence? Had the green liquid wiped all of Hordak's memories this time? Imp emitted a squeak. She considered telling him to go away. Yet she couldn't do it.

What was stopping Catra? Was she going soft? She loathed the notion of becoming vulnerable. Adora had been weak. And look what happened. Letting Horde Prime chip her could make her compliant, but it would mean a loss of free will. She was her own person. No one should dictate her actions. Once she became the leader of the Galactic Horde, she would be in control. However, the goal seemed more unattainable with time. Horde Prime came forward, arms behind his back as he grinned. The polite act was unnerving.

"You haven't disposed of this thing," Horde Prime said, a growl in his voice as he pointed at Imp. "As of late, you have not heeded my orders. I was going to give you a task, little sister. I may have to send you to the purification chamber. It will be unpleasant, but also good for you. You can't fool me with your feeble attempt to manipulate me."

Catra's blood ran cold. Every muscle in her body froze. "I…" She tried to think of something to say. "You can't get rid of me. I will help you find the runestones and the princesses. It'll be quicker to

conquer Etheria if we work together. I know how to fight the Princess Alliance. I'm already loyal to you without the prototype."

Horde Prime turned around, his back facing Catra. "You're dismissed."

With a trembling nod, Catra picked up Imp and began running. The forest was familiar to her. *The Whispering Woods.* She wasn't sure if the dismissal meant a removal from the Galactic Horde, or simply an order. She failed to rise to the top. Even if she did find the runestones and confronted the Princess Alliance, Horde Prime wouldn't accept her back into his army. To him, she was expendable, chip or no chip. The Rebellion viewed her as the enemy. So that left her no place to go. If the Rebellion won, it would mean either a life on the run, or permanent imprisonment.

On the other hand, if Horde Prime won, Etheria would be no more. Both outcomes were unpleasant. Catra's foot met a log, and she tumbled forward. Imp sprung out of her arms. She forced herself up, grunting. It was the result of not watching where one was going. At least she didn't run into Prime's minions or the Princess Alliance. The last thing she wanted to do was stumble into an ambush. Were Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio on the run, too? Or did someone chip them?

Catra scooped Imp up and continued traveling on foot. The minutes lengthened into hours as she wandered to no destination in particular. At the sound of bushes rustling, she halted. Her ears perked up as she held her breath. It could be a chipped individual, a clone, or a member of the Rebellion. To her surprise, a trio stepped out of hiding. She recognized them from the Horde. Lonnie scowled at her, and so did Kyle and Rogelio. Their eyes were normal, meaning no chips.

"I thought Horde Prime took you," Lonnie said. "What are you doing with Imp?"

"He was alone on the Velvet Glove," Catra replied. "You can take him."

"We're not here to exchange pleasantries. You were cruel to us. You didn't let us take a break. It's why we left. There's one thing you should do."

Catra lowered her brows. "What is it?"

"Apologize."

"I don't have time for this."

Lonnie pointed a taser at Catra. "I don't want to hear any excuses. You've been mean to us our entire lives. And lately? You were despicable. Our former friend, Adora, was chipped."

Catra's tail swished from side to side. "I don't care about Adora. I worked hard to be the Force Captain. Now I'm on my own."

"You have Imp. And stop being stubborn."

"You want me to apologize?"

Lonnie arched a single brow. "Are you gonna say it or not?"

"Fine. I'm sorry," Catra said through clenched teeth. It was the least she could do, as reluctant as she was.

"Thank you," Lonnie replied.

Imp jumped into Rogelio's arms. He didn't seem to mind holding the creature. No one would expect him to have a tender side. Catra moved past the trio, still unsure of her destination. Where would she find shelter? In an abandoned campground? In a cave? Perhaps a hidden cottage? Her palm brushed the whip on her belt. It wouldn't be wise to be unprepared. Also, she had years of Horde training on her side. She strode to a rushing river, checked the area for any foes, and sat near a tree. She could take a break for a while. Leaves crunched, alerting her to a possible attacker. Peeking out from her hiding spot, she watched for someone. Or a bot.

Catra climbed the tree and reached the nearest branch without making a sound. She stared at the ground below. Clones searched the area. Were they hunting her down? A whir of an approaching drone penetrated the silence, garnering her attention. The bot drew closer; its camera scrutinized everything in sight. She unrolled the whip, lashed it around the bot, and hurled it at the ground. Her actions alerted the clones to her presence.

Catra unfurled the whip again, wrapping it around a clone's leg. One yank, and the clone fell. She jumped onto his chest, dug her claws into him, and carved deep scars. Green blood spewed from his wounds. The other clone approached her from behind, preparing to grab her. Thinking fast, she scaled the tree and clung to a branch closest to her foe. She swung herself around it and kicked him down.

Catra broke into a run. Knowing Horde Prime, he would tell his cronies to stalk her. She needed to find a place to hide by tonight. The abandoned Horde hideout wasn't a good option. Sparkles knew where it was, and the princesses might go there to flee the clones and bots. Catra didn't want to wake up to an angry queen looming over her.

Glimmer and the princesses embarked on a search for Adora. According to a report, the blonde visited a town. She couldn't help but wonder if Horde Prime forced her to attack that place. Checking the map, she estimated the distance. So, Adora had been in Elberon. It wasn't too far off. Adora had been gone for more than a week. It had given the galactic warlord enough time to chip the blonde. Glimmer tightened her grip on the staff, allowing anger to settle in her chest. She would make Horde Prime regret controlling the hero.

The group walked into Elberon. Glimmer was sure she had come here before. Her heart ached as she dwelled on memories of her mother. She wished she was a better daughter. Shaking her head, she reminded herself to focus on the mission. It wouldn't be good

to think about the past. Adora needed her. But would the queen even be a hero for the blonde?

"Your Majesty?" One of the villagers called out.

Glimmer glanced at the speaker. "Do you need something?"

"Are you searching for She-Ra? She betrayed us."

"No. Horde Prime forced her to do things she wouldn't do. Where did she go?"

"This way."

Glimmer led the princesses out of the village and entered the woods. She thought of Spinnerella and the hologram. A silhouette lingered by a pine tree. It was tall and muscular. Was Adora already in her She-Ra form? Didn't her friend break the sword? The figure emerged. So, it was Adora. The blonde's She-Ra form was anything but beautiful. It was green and gray, with the Horde emblem on the front.

"Adora, what has he done to you?" Glimmer murmured.

"Here to yell at me, Your Majesty?" Adora said in a voice that wasn't hers. "You brought me pain. Horde Prime brought me healing. I will be the hero he needs."

"Adora, fight the chip! This isn't you. Come back to me."

"No. I won't return to my old life."

Perfuma advanced. "Adora, listen-"

Adora charged at the princesses. Mermista and Frosta jumped to the left. Glimmer teleported Perfuma out of the way and reappeared a few feet behind the warrior. Glimmer detected something metallic on Adora's neck. Mermista summoned water tendrils and launched them at the blonde. Adora deflected the tendrils with the sword. Perfuma conjured vines and expelled

them. The plants snaked around Adora's entire body except her head and neck. Adora broke free, sliced the vines, and lunged at the queen and the plant princess.

Another teleport, and Glimmer materialized in front of the bushes. She unleashed a spell at Adora, intending to hit the chip. The blonde sidestepped. Frosta conjured ice knuckles, sprung toward Adora, and aimed for the chip. The warrior whirled around and drove a fist into Frosta's abdomen.

The impact sent Frosta flying into a tree. Mermista shot the water tendrils at the chip, only to miss Adora's neck by an inch. Glimmer traced a rune in the air and shoved it forward. Once again, Adora dodged. The warrior stood still. Horde Prime began speaking through Adora's mouth.

"Your pathetic attempts to wrest the weapon out of my control amuses me. The warrior is my soldier, and I won't let you take her," Horde Prime said. "Before I brought her into the light, she felt like a failure. She hoped you would come to your senses. Hoped things would get better. The hurt ate her up inside. She-Ra was miserable on Etheria. Now she doesn't have to worry about disappointing you and your weak friends."

"Screw you, Horde Prime! Let her go!" Glimmer demanded.

"You still want her back, don't you? How far will you go to 'save' her, Your Majesty? What will you do? I'll let you two catch up."

Adora reacted before Glimmer could teleport. The tip of the sword nicked the queen's ankle. It didn't go deep, but it would bleed. Glimmer would worry about it later. Perfuma's vines restrained Adora, pulling her backward. The warrior freed herself and rushed toward the plant princess, ready to strike.

"Adora, let us help you!" Perfuma shouted as she jumped out of the way.

Glimmer expelled a rune at the chip and missed. Adora's sword sped through the air. The queen blocked the blows, frantically

checking for an opening. Adora rammed a foot into her abdomen, knocking her off-balance. The ground came up to meet her spine and her head. Water tendrils collided into the blonde's chest. Adora fell onto her back, and Glimmer stood. Bright blue eyes glistened with tears. Pain and anger mingled in Adora's eyes as she glanced at Glimmer.

"Why?" Adora asked, voice cracking. "Why did you blame me for Angella's death?"

"Adora, I-" Glimmer began.

"I tried so hard to take care of you. And I failed."

"You're not a failure. You brought hope to the Rebellion. I'm sorry for lashing out at you. My mother's death isn't your fault. It was her choice to save us all."

"Glim- ugh!" Adora's eyes fluttered shut, and when she opened them, her eyes turned green. She shot up, advanced, and swung the sword at Glimmer.

Glimmer teleported, then reappeared by Mermista's side. Her hands glowed as she summoned a rune and discharged it at Adora. The spell should work.

The rune sailed toward the chip. Adora staggered upon impact, eyes flickering as she descended to her knees. One minute, her eyes were blue. Next minute, green. Glimmer observed the warrior, waiting for the magic to work. The others also watched Adora. Sparks shot out from the chip.

Adora's hand shook as she reached for the chip. Then, her hand halted. Was she trying to resist Horde Prime's control? Glimmer's breath lodged in her throat. Should she cast another spell? The blonde mumbled something incomprehensible.

"Adora, fight it!" Glimmer said. "Don't let Prime win. We need you here. I need you here! You're my hero, not Horde Prime's soldier."

Adora grabbed the chip and yanked it off. A glow enveloped her as she reverted to her usual form. Pieces of the chip fell to the grass. A sharp beep resounded, then went quiet. The blonde reclined on her side, unconscious. Glimmer closed the distance between herself and Adora, sat by her, and pulled the taller woman onto her lap. Glimmer cradled Adora in her arms. Adora was lighter than she remembered. Perfuma, Mermista, and Frosta approached them, staring at the unconscious woman.

"Adora, are you okay?" Glimmer asked.

Adora's eyes opened, looking up at Glimmer. The blonde wore a subtle smile. Glimmer was glad Adora was back, nestled in her arms. Her friend seemed tired. Being controlled must have drained the blonde's energy. And did she see scratch marks above Adora's collarbone? Had Catra been with her? The queen heard the hero whispering. They were finally together after a week or so of being apart.

"Let's go home," Glimmer said.

Adora was waiting in a forest when someone approached. Or rather, a group of people. A short woman with pink and purple hair was their leader. It was Glimmer, Queen of Bright Moon. The others - Mermista, Frosta, and Perfuma - accompanied the queen. Adora and Glimmer started to talk, and Perfuma joined the conversation. It was when Adora charged at them. She blocked Mermista's water powers, sliced the plants, and attempted to attack Glimmer and Perfuma. Adora punched Frosta, and not long after, she allowed Horde Prime to speak through her.

The battle continued, and Perfuma mentioned letting the princesses help. Something wet slammed into Adora. The sense of dreaming dissipated. She asked Glimmer why the queen blamed her. Glimmer apologized for lashing out at her. It sounded genuine, and as Adora prepared to respond, something yanked her back into the dreamlike state.

Adora attempted to land a hit. The queen teleported, and something made Adora stagger. Her mind switched between reality and the dreamlike state as her legs gave out under her. She struggled to reach for her neck. Horde Prime began telling her to complete the task he had given her.

Everything that happened next was a blur. Darkness flooded Adora's vision. Green eyes came into view. A sensation of icy palms brushed her face. Goosebumps formed on her skin. A cold and menacing voice murmured something she couldn't understand. She couldn't see the owner of the voice. Someone wrapped their hands around her neck, tightening their grip.

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Adora's eyes fluttered open, and she sat up, taking deep breaths. The nightmare refused to stop haunting her. It felt so real. A familiar blue cape covered part of her body. She had no idea how she got here, as her mind was hazy. The back of her neck throbbed with pain. Why did it hurt so much? Glimmer entered the tent and sat next to her.

"You're awake," Glimmer said. "How are you feeling?"

"I… I don't know. Why does my neck hurt?" Adora replied.

"Horde Prime chipped you. Entrapta removed it when you were unconscious."

Upon hearing those two sentences, memories threatened to surface in Adora's thoughts. Her pulse raced as she ran her fingers through her hair. Then, her fingertips met the affected area on her neck. The dam broke. Flashes zipped through her mind. An unsuccessful escape attempt, the murky green pool, Horde Prime looming over her, and letting him control her. Images from the nightmare blurred together, and she suppressed a whimper. A pair of arms wrapped around her. A soothing voice brought her to reality, and she melted into the embrace.

"Adora, it's okay. You're here, and I won't let anyone hurt you. I'll protect you," Glimmer said. "Can you count from one hundred?"

Adora nodded as she began counting. Her heartbeat slowed down, and her body was no longer tense. She tried to focus on the positives; she was home. Entrapta had gotten rid of the chip while Adora was unconscious. Horde Prime couldn't access the blonde's mind anymore.

"Feeling better?" Glimmer asked.

"Yes. Thanks," Adora replied.

Glimmer released Adora. "Do you remember anything that happened?"

Adora paused for a moment. She had been a hostage on the Velvet Glove. Catra had spoken to her a few times. Horde Prime had tried to convince her to join his army, and she had said no. Everything else was a blur. She peeked at Glimmer's leg. Someone must have bandaged the queen's ankle. A brief flash of the blade touching it arose. So did an image of kicking the queen.

"I did this," Adora said. "I hurt you."

Glimmer held Adora's hand. "No. Horde Prime was controlling you. You wouldn't do it on purpose. You're kind, and you're a hero. I'm sorry for saying horrible things to you. I'm sorry for listening to Shadow Weaver."

"Glim, I forgive you. I need to apologize, too. Not just for attacking you. I'm sorry for trying to control what you did. I wanted to keep you safe. As a result, I went overboard. You're your own person. You're the bravest person I know."

"We both messed up, didn't we?"

"Yeah." Adora swung her legs over the edge of the cot. "I need to stop Prime. I want to see how the others are doing. And I must figure out a way to turn into She-Ra."

Glimmer rested her hands on Adora's shoulders. "Adora, don't rush back into things. We just rescued you, and you need to take a break. Our friends are guarding the camp."

"I can't let Horde Prime take over the rest of Etheria. Our planet needs She-Ra."

"Even heroes need rest. Can you take a breather for now?"

Adora sighed. "I will."

The sun was an hour from setting, and Catra settled on spending the night in the Fright Zone. It wasn't an ideal spot, as it brought to mind many memories of this dump. The headquarters was the ghost of its former self, rubble cluttering the metal floors. Remains of broken bots lingered, waiting for a geeky princess to repair them. Entrapta wouldn't come here anytime. There were holes in roofs, and every room was empty. Once, this place teemed with activity. Now, it was silent. Catra took the time to explore the hallways, looking for any signs of intruders. She would hate it if a bot or a clone ambushed her while she slumbered.

Catra stormed to the pier overlooking the docks and sat, observing the area. Scorpia used to sit here with her. Was the scorpioni woman chipped? If not, what was Scorpia doing right now? Catra drew her knees to her chest, dwelling on past events. A memory of Adora surfaced…

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"Adora, admit it. You love being in first place!" Catra spat as she swung her staff at Adora. It collided into the blonde's side, knocking her to the floor.

"Catra, you don't have to do that!" Adora replied, forcing herself up.

They had just completed their training session. As usual, Adora was the winner. Catra was apparently second-best. Both preteens

walked into the hallway. No matter what Catra did, she didn't receive any praise. Adora always received commendation from Shadow Weaver. Would anyone notice the magicat's efforts for once? Adora wasn't the only young cadet in the Horde. There were others, such as Lonnie. Catra followed Adora to the bunk room and plopped onto their shared bed.

"You did great during training," Adora said.

"Yeah, right." Catra rolled her eyes. "You got first place. Everyone around here thinks you're special. I could try my hardest, and they would praise you instead of me."

"Well, you don't follow the rules. I do, because there are consequences for stepping out of line."

"And yet you don't get any punishments. Shadow Weaver and everyone else around here have a problem with me. She tortures me whenever she has the chance."

Adora reached for Catra's shoulder, but the magicat swatted the blonde's hand away. There was a flash of hurt in Adora's eyes. A tear slid down Adora's cheek. For someone training so much in the Horde, the blonde was emotional. Subtle footsteps entered the room, drawing their attention. Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes at Catra.

"You instigated a fight, insolent brat. I do not find it surprising to hear of such disgraceful behavior. I will not allow you to hinder Adora from her potential," Shadow Weaver said. "Have you forgotten what I have told you? Adora will become a ruthless Force Captain once she's old enough. She doesn't need you to drag her down."

Coils of Shadow Weaver's magic snaked around Catra's limbs. The old witch could punish the magicat again. Would Shadow Weaver use unpleasant magic on Catra? Lock her in a room with a monster? Dozens of unnerving thoughts whizzed through Catra's mind. The sorceress glared at Adora.

"Adora, you are a Horde soldier. You do not want to show weakness. Unless you hide your emotions, you will be vulnerable. However, you did an excellent job during the training session."

Adora wiped her tears away, then nodded. "Yes, Shadow Weaver." She gave Catra a sideways glance. "Catra didn't mean to hit me. She didn't realize the training session ended. So, please don't hurt her."

"I've told you several times to keep her under control." Shadow Weaver approached Adora and rested a palm on the blonde's cheek. "I know you're fond of her. However, don't let this brat stand in the way of your training. Do you understand?"

"Yes."

The sorceress left the room. Catra looked into Adora's eyes. The blonde frowned. Usually, both girls would go through the routine of making promises to each other. This time, neither girl said a word. Then…

Catra gripped Adora's shirt, nails digging into the fabric. "Apparently I'm in the way of your so-called potential. And I'm dragging you down. You always get praise. What did everyone see in you? All I see is a girl trying to take the spotlight and playing the hero!" She didn't care how harsh her voice sounded. "I'm always getting the worst punishments!"

Adora grabbed Catra's wrist and moved the magicat's hands away. "I wasn't taking the spotlight. And I don't want us to start fighting. We promised to look out for each other."

Catra pounded Adora's cheek. "Shut. Up!"

Tears shone in Adora's eyes. "Sorry I said anything."

…

Catra allowed the memory to fade. The same Adora who promised to look out for her had been willing to leave the Horde. Catra had

gone after her, doing anything to bring her back to the Horde. And what did the Princess Alliance do? They foiled the magicat's plans in some way or another.

She didn't run away from the Horde. She ran away from you!

Catra gritted her teeth. She was sure she wasn't the problem. In the Horde, soldiers must act tough, or they would be shamed for being weak. The Force Captain title was an important one. Whenever she failed in a mission, Hordak would punish her. His reaction to her letting Shadow Weaver escape was the last straw. She had learned a lesson. Don't be a caring person. After the portal incident, she had started ordering soldiers around and conquering Etheria.

Catra rose to her height, entered the headquarters, and searched the building for her room. A distant echo of footsteps halted her movements. She wasn't alone. There was always something shitty going on in the Fright Zone. It could have been cursed with bad luck. She darted to the weapon chamber. Of all the weapons on the shelves and tables, she chose the taser gun. A staff could knock someone to the floor, but the tasers would render anyone unconscious. Idling on the pier had probably increased her chances of an enemy detecting her. It was a stupid choice, yet she did it anyways. The door slammed open, revealing a clone.

On instinct, Catra rammed the taser gun into the clone's chest, electrocuting him. More footsteps advanced. Once again, she was fighting for her life. She sprung into the hallway, facing more clones and bots. Horde Prime's minions weren't allowing her to catch a break. Her foes surrounded her, and she tasered the one standing in front. As the others began to move, she sped through the opening and leaped onto a stack of crates. Unfurling the whip, she aimed for a drone. Then, she swung it toward the wall. Upon impact, it shattered into pieces.

"Anyone else wanna come at me?" Catra asked in a smug tone. "I defeated some of your siblings!"

A bipedal robot pointed an arm cannon at Catra and expelled a beam. The magicat evaded the laser and swung the whip at its cannon. Her weapon wrapped around it. A sharp pull, and the robot lost its balance. She picked up an empty crate and chucked it at the clones, knocking them off their feet. In unison, they jumped to the side. The confrontation lasted until midnight.

Catra smirked at the sight of her fallen enemies. Exhaustion crept into her bones. She could keep running all night. However, she wouldn't have any more energy for tomorrow. If she slept in her old room, an enemy could capture her. There was one thing she knew for sure. She wouldn't surrender to Horde Prime.

Chapter End Notes

Comments / Kudos appreciated 🙂

Secure

Chapter Notes

I have been working on drafts for a future multi-chapter She-Ra story. It's a Knight Glimmer AU.

Adora made her way to the tent flap. The outdoors were blurry. There was something she should do, but she couldn't figure out what it was. The moment she left the tent, the scenery transitioned to a 'purification' chamber. How did she get here? Did Prime kidnap her again? Whispers reached her ears as she rubbed her arms. Distorted chants repeated themselves. She proceeded into a hallway and searched for an exit. Out of the corner of her eye, she detected a flash of messy brown hair and a tail. A heavy thud echoed off the sterile walls. She sensed a sinister presence lurking nearby.

"The queen snatched you from the light," an icy voice said. "Do you expect those pesky Etherians to welcome you home after you failed them? You're giving them false hope."

Cold hands found Adora's shoulders. A chill stampeded down her spine as she tensed. She knew who those hands belonged to. Horde Prime leaned closer, his mouth inches from her ear. She tried to move, but she was frozen to the spot. Why wasn't she defending herself? Why was she letting fear take over? Heroes shouldn't be afraid of anything. Here she was, standing as still as a statue. Prime was touching her without her consent.

"She-Ra, without my help, you're unable to tap into such power," Horde Prime said. "Return to the light."

Adora's gaze swept over her shoulder. "No. I won't. I will stop you."

Horde Prime let out a dark chuckle. "You are the key to Etheria's heart. However, if you resist, I will find a way to activate the

superweapon without you. How can you stop me if you can't awaken your power? Etherians see you as a failure. You already disappointed them many times."

Adora launched a fist at Horde Prime, and he caught it. He shot his hand at her neck and began squeezing. Everything went black. Flashes of being thrown into the green pool, attacking a village, battling her friends with the intent to murder them, and more unpleasant images arose. A phantom sensation of Prime's hands brushing her face, neck, and shoulders lingered.

…

Adora sat up, screaming. Her racing heart threatened to jump out of her chest as she glanced around. For a moment, the blonde saw a silhouette. As soon as she blinked, it was gone. Could Horde Prime see into her mind despite the removal of the chip? Someone grabbed her wrist, and a purple glow chased away the darkness. She peeked at Glimmer. The scream must have awakened the queen.

"Did you have a nightmare?" Glimmer asked. "And do you want to talk about it?"

"Yes. Horde Prime got into my head," Adora said. "How is he still able to see into my mind?" As she spoke, fragments of the nightmare surfaced.

"He can't. You're not chipped," Glimmer replied.

Adora lifted her hand to the nape of her neck. She had to be sure the chip was gone. And it was. Why did she have a nightmare about Horde Prime, then? Images of the Velvet Glove flooded her mind. She wished the memories would stop coming, but they continued the assault on her brain. Glimmer took Adora's hands and squeezed them. The queen's touch was warm and reassuring. It was a stark contrast to the unwelcome touches from Horde Prime. The shorter woman radiated an aura of comfort.

"We need to get some sleep," Glimmer said. "Are you feeling calm?"

Adora reclined on the bed. "A little."

"Do you want to cuddle?"

"Of course."

The purple glow disappeared, and both women cuddled beneath the covers. Closing her eyes, Adora relaxed her body. The scent of lavender wafted into her nose. Soft hums drifted into her ears, and she realized the sound was coming from Glimmer. Warmth bloomed in her chest. A heaviness weighed upon her eyelids and her body. At first, she resisted the pull of slumber, fearing the return of the nightmare. As time passed, her awareness of the waking world trickled into unconsciousness. A heavy darkness overwhelmed her.

Morning came. Glimmer and Adora stepped out of the tent. Mermista, Netossa, and Castaspella gathered by the main tent, chatting. Judging by their expressions, Glimmer figured that something was wrong. The queen and the blonde approached the group. Castaspella turned her attention to Glimmer and Adora.

"Horde Prime's forces have been relentlessly attacking the magical dome. The sorcerers are exhausted," Castaspella said. "We may have to find a place to hide."

Netossa frowned. "I'll keep looking for Spinny."

Adora furrowed her brows. "Is Horde Prime controlling Spinnerella?"

"Yes. Also, Sea Hawk is still chipped."

An explosion interrupted the conversation. Mermista, Netossa, and the other princesses sprung to action, battling clones and bots. Bow shot arrows at the drones. Castaspella and Micah conjured

runes and downed a few enemies. Glimmer unleashed a barrage of kinetic blasts at her foes. More and more kept coming. A yell pierced the air. At first, it sounded like Adora's transformation words. Another shout, this time of fear, caught Glimmer's attention. First, Adora hadn't turned into She-Ra. Second, a group of clones and robots surrounded the blonde. Adora fell onto her back, holding up an arm to shield herself. A laser grazed her right side, leaving behind a bloody line and eliciting a cry from her lips.

Glimmer zipped out of this reality and reappeared in front of Adora. She expelled powerful spells at the clones and bots. More of them advanced; she summoned a magical shield to protect both women. Micah, Castaspella, Bow, and the princesses took down the rest of their enemies. Glimmer helped Adora up.

"Are you okay?" Glimmer asked.

"I'll be fine. I can handle it," Adora replied in a shaky voice.

"You're bleeding."

"Don't worry about me."

Another blast resounded in the air. Glimmer led everyone into the woods, and they continued fighting off their enemies. A memory of the abandoned Horde hideout arose. Not many people knew about it. Once they reached a clearing, hidden from the prying eyes of Horde Prime's soldiers, the queen glanced at her friends.

"I know the perfect place to go," Glimmer said. "I'll teleport us there."

Glimmer grabbed Adora's and Bow's hands, then teleported them to the abandoned Horde hideout. Her friends seemed surprised, and as they opened their mouths to speak, she zipped through another dimension. Within a fraction of a second, she appeared in the clearing. She did the same with the others - teleporting them to the hideout. It took two minutes of going back and forth. Now she was done. Adora wore a different jacket. The blonde or

someone else must have bandaged Adora's wound while Glimmer was busy whisking the group to safety.

"Isn't this a Horde building?" Adora asked.

"Used to be. We're the only ones here," Glimmer said.

"How do you know about - oh, wait. You once told me you came here. Doesn't Catra know this place?"

"She did, but if I see her again, I'll ensure she doesn't cause any trouble."

Adora walked to a crate and sat. "Without She-Ra, I'm useless. I couldn't transform into her. Fighting is harder. She-Ra can do all those amazing things. My normal self, however, is weak. I tried to escape Horde Prime's ship, and Catra caught me." She stared at her lap. "She-Ra would escape the Velvet Glove with ease. I didn't."

Glimmer caressed Adora's back, careful not to touch the scars. "You're not weak and useless. She-Ra or no She-Ra, you're the strongest person I know."

Adora looked into Glimmer's eyes. "Even though I'm not eight feet tall and carrying a sword?"

"Yes. And what had Catra been doing on Horde Prime's ship?"

"She visited my cell a few times and taunted me."

A flash of anger surfaced as Glimmer listened. She had always hated Catra for putting Adora through so much pain. In the past, the magicat had left Adora for dead in the First One's temple, carved bleeding scars into the hero's back, made her go berserk using a corrupted disk, and kidnapped her. There were times when the magicat tried to kill the blonde. Adora had suffered from nightmares about Catra. Glimmer remembered bandaging Adora's scars after the Battle of Bright Moon.

The princesses and the others arranged the sleeping areas. Entrapta set up a makeshift lab behind a stack of crates. A meeting table idled by the fallen bridge. Shadow Weaver spoke to Micah and Castaspella. They discussed the Heart of Etheria and using magic. Micah yelled at Shadow Weaver. She responded by telling him she was helping the Rebellion. The sorceress narrowed her eyes at him before ending the conversation. Then, Shadow Weaver began approaching Glimmer and Adora.

"Adora, you are allowing Horde Prime to take too much ground. Etheria needs She-Ra," Shadow Weaver said as she rested a hand on Adora's shoulder. "You must summon She-Ra. Now is not the time to idle around. Did years of training not teach you anything? You are a warrior, not someone who is incompetent. So stop pretending to be the person who needs saving."

Glimmer cleared her throat, garnering Shadow Weaver's attention. "Adora does not need your manipulation. You're going back into the magical prison. I'll come up with a suitable punishment once the war is over. If you try anything funny…" Sparkling orbs encased her hands. "I won't hesitate to deck you."

"Relax, Your Majesty. I'm not the enemy," Shadow Weaver said.

Alwyn was one of the few places untouched by clones and droids. Catra stretched her limbs, yawning. She slept in one of the houses last night. The magicat made her way to the dirt path. She pulled a ration bar from her bag and bit off some pieces. Memories of the Crimson Waste bubbled to the surface. She had been the leader of a gang. But it was temporary, as she had thought she found what she was searching for. The magicat gazed at the sky. So far, no foes have come. A part of her wanted some excitement right now.

Catra had observed Adora's lack of resistance shortly after the clones chipped the blonde. She had no desire to wind up in the same situation. What was Adora doing at the moment? Catra swore under her breath. Why was she thinking about Adora

again? Why did she care? There wouldn't be any chance of making amends anytime soon. A distant noise halted the magicat's train of thought. Guess she was wrong about Alwyn. She stashed the ration bar into her bag and scrutinized the area. There wasn't a single clone or bot in sight.

Catra gripped her whip, ears perking up as her eyes scanned the trees and bushes. Something moved. A gust ripped through Alwyn. Then, a wide-hipped woman with light pink skin blocked her, levitating. It was definitely one of the princesses. The woman's eyes glowed green as she wore a blank expression.

"Surrender to Horde Prime," the woman said.

Catra swore she could hear Prime's voice mixed in. "I'm not surrendering to him!"

"You have chosen to remain in the darkness." The woman conjured a tornado. "Horde Prime will cleanse Etheria of its rebellious inhabitants."

The tornado drew Catra in, spinning her in the air. She couldn't stand a chance against the wind princess. And being chipped made this woman dangerous. The next thing Catra knew, the gale launched her at the trees. She collided against the branches and fell into a thorny bush. Groaning, she forced herself up. A teleportation chime alerted her to Glimmer's sudden presence in Alwyn. A dark-skinned woman with silver-blue hair accompanied the queen. What were they doing here? Were they tracking down the wind princess?

"Spinny, I'm not giving up on you!" The dark-skinned woman said.

Glimmer unleashed a rune. The spell surged into the chip, causing it to emit sparks and beeps. "Spinny" descended to the ground. The dark-skinned woman hugged "Spinny" and punched the chip. Glimmer stared in Catra's direction. Did the queen notice the magicat? Or did Glimmer sense someone watching them?

"Netossa, stay with Spinnerella. I think I saw someone," Glimmer said.

"It could be a clone or a bot," Netossa said.

Glimmer made her way to the bush. "I don't think it is." She turned her attention to Catra. "Are you leading the clones and bots to us?"

Catra crossed her arms. "No. I'm on my own."

"I thought you were working for Horde Prime. Adora told me you were on the ship with her."

"Wasn't Horde Prime controlling her?"

"The princesses and I freed Adora from his control." Glimmer looked around, as if checking the area for an enemy. "What were you doing here, anyways?"

"I spent the night in Alwyn. And Spinnerella showed up. She told me to surrender to Horde Prime. I said no, and she attacked me. Anyways, I'm going to leave."

"And where will you go?" Glimmer asked. "After the war, assuming the Rebellion wins, I will punish you for your crimes. You helped Hordak conquer Etheria. You set off the portal that nearly destroyed everything. There is no way you will run away from consequences forever." She grabbed Catra's wrist. "You're coming with me." She peeked at Netossa and Spinnerella. "We're going back to the hideout. I'm taking Catra."

Glimmer was serious. Before Catra could say anything, the queen touched Netossa. A tingle overwhelmed Catra's body. A sparkling purple glow flooded her vision. Was the queen teleporting them? She became aware of the sensation of zipping through another dimension. The next thing she knew, she was standing in the abandoned hideout. Members of the Princess Alliance glanced at the four women. The moment Adora saw Catra, the blonde

charged at the magicat. Adora pinned Catra to the ground, holding both wrists. Rage darkened Adora's blue eyes.

"I bet you manipulated her into bringing you here!" Adora spat.

"She captured me. According to Sparkles, I would be punished for my crimes once the Rebellion wins," Catra said. "Can you get off of me? I thought she said you weren't chipped."

Adora punched Catra's cheek. "You made my life a living hell! I won't be surprised if you have any more tricks up your sleeve."

A new voice interrupted the conversation. Scorpia pulled Adora back, and the blonde continued struggling. Catra stood, widening her stance in case Adora wanted to continue fighting. Frosta lunged at Catra, her ice fist colliding into the magicat's jaw. Mermista unleashed water tendrils at Catra. Perfuma came forward, yet the flower princess didn't attack. Catra was surprised Perfuma didn't strike her. Scorpia frowned, but didn't display any hostility. Bow and the others stopped to watch. A shout pierced the magicat's ears. As she prepared to defend herself, a pigtail slammed into her.

"That's for sending me to Beast Island!" Entrapta yelled. "You used me!"

"Anyone else want to hit me?" Catra spat. "Am I everyone's punching bag now?"

Glimmer glared at Catra. "There is something we want you to do. Apologize to everyone you've hurt."

Catra took a deep breath. "I'm sorry for being awful and trying to destroy Etheria. I wanted to be in control of something. Being a Force Captain gave me that feeling. There's no excuse for what I did. I do not expect you guys to forgive me. And you don't owe me anything."

Adora scowled. "I hope the apology is genuine. You're right about us not owing you anything. I don't know if we'll forgive you after

the war ends. I hope you're not secretly planning to pull a trick on us. While we're talking, our world is going to shit."

Catra expected to hear such words coming from Adora's mouth. And she wasn't surprised when the others lashed out at her. She couldn't blame them for being furious at her. Even if she did something to make it up to them, they wouldn't forget everything she had done. Assuming they didn't imprison her on the spot, she could try to help the Rebellion.

Glimmer, Adora, and the princesses gathered around the meeting table. Catra walked to a corner. The magicat leaned against the wall, tail swishing back and forth. The princesses discussed finding Sea Hawk and removing the chip from his neck. Catra sensed someone watching her. She glanced in a specific direction. Sure enough, a familiar woman was lingering in a magical prison. *Shadow Weaver.* The old witch narrowed her eyes. How long was the sorceress in the magical prison? Would the Rebellion do something about Shadow Weaver after the war?

"They're still keeping you around?" Catra asked, glowering at the woman who made her childhood a living hell. "You must have pissed them off enough to make them imprison you. You're despicable."

"Says the one who almost blew up the world," Shadow Weaver said. "All you do is cause problems."

"Listen here, old lady. I've been trying to change my ways. And what have you been doing? Trying to manipulate people into doing what you want them to do, all because you're desperate for power?" Catra squared her shoulders. She refused to show any weakness. "You only care about yourself, hag. And you think that Adora is special. However, she doesn't seem to want anything to do with you. Even the queen, who you once held hands with, has put you in your prison."

"This is the thanks I get for raising you? You have never been grateful for anything I've done. The only reason I took you in is

that Adora wanted to be your friend," Shadow Weaver said.

"I guess you and Hordak enjoyed stealing babies and raising them into mindless soldiers. And I'd rather not be talking to you right now."

"Get out of my sight, then. Your disrespect is unnecessary."

"Shut up."

The wind howled as Adora stepped out of the hideout. Storm clouds churned in the sky, blocking out any light that would otherwise shine through. Barren trees swayed in the gust. All over the land, the grass had turned brown. Despite wearing long sleeves, the temperature was icy. What was going on? Shadows materialized by the trees, stretching high enough to reach the forest ceiling. A familiar silhouette appeared, holding a staff. Adora might not see her face, but she knew who it was. She closed the distance between herself and Glimmer. The queen looked up. Instead of violet eyes, there were pools of darkness. A strong gust whipped the women's hair.

"Do you realize what you have done by breaking the Sword of Protection? Did you expect any consequences for such an action? Because of you, Etheria is gone. There is no going back," a distorted voice said. "It's all your fault. You failed. And you let Horde Prime control you."

"I'm so sorry," Adora whispered.

"Ha. As if your apology can fix things. All our hopes and dreams are gone. Every home? Destroyed. Lives ruined and taken."

"I could do better, I swear. Please give me another chance!"

However, Glimmer ignored Adora's words. A powerful gust blew all the debris through the air. Thunder roared above them, and as Adora prepared to speak more, the queen vanished in a cloud of black smoke. The ground shook and broke apart, revealing a

chasm. Adora fell into the abyss, and darkness flooded her vision. Flashes of all her failures and mistakes danced before her eyes, taunting her. A faint voice spoke her name. She couldn't see the speaker, yet it sounded familiar. There was worry in their tone. She glanced around. Green eyes stared at her, accompanied by sinister laughter. An invisible presence tightened its grip on her neck and her chest.

…

Adora jolted awake, her gaze darting across the area as her surroundings came into focus. Her entire body was shaking. Were the nightmares becoming frequent? How would she get a good night's sleep? Didn't she need energy to fight in the war? Aware of a hand on her shoulder, she looked to the side. Glimmer made eye contact, observing her body language.

"It's okay. You're safe," Glimmer said.

Heat bloomed in Adora's cheeks. "Sorry for waking you up, Glim. I keep having nightmares. You don't have to worry about me in the middle of the night. And yet here we are."

"No need to apologize, Starlight. Nightmares can be a pain, especially during the war. We'll get through this together. I'm here for you."

Hearing the reassuring words made Adora feel secure, as though everything would be okay. It was like seeking shelter in a storm, knowing it would pass. She remained still, letting Glimmer caress her. Soon, she forgot about her nightmare. Good riddance. She buried her face in Glimmer's shoulder, inhaling the scent of lavender.

"Feeling better?" Glimmer asked.

"Yes. Thank you," Adora replied.

"I'm glad to hear that."

Both women reclined on the cot, holding each other in an embrace. Adora's eyes fluttered shut, and she slowed her breathing. Despite her tiredness, she couldn't fall asleep. The hours dragged on as she waited for sleep to come. To make matters worse, she couldn't stop thinking about the fate of Etheria. Her heart was thumping as fast as possible. Why couldn't it slow down? She knew she was safe. There had to be a way to make her pulse stop racing. Then, she remembered something. There were times when Glimmer told her to count from one hundred. And so she did, counting backward.

Within minutes, Adora's heartbeat was calmer. Yawning, she let herself slip into unconsciousness. Instead of a nightmare, all she saw was blackness. Occasionally, a blurry image would materialize, but it didn't transform into a dream. It felt nice, as she didn't have to worry about a sudden awakening. Her breaths deepened. Not once had she moved a single muscle. There was a vague awareness of time whizzing by.

The next thing Adora knew, a flurry of activity filled the room. Someone nudged her, and she opened her eyes. She could see Glimmer getting ready for the day. The queen seemed energetic. How did the shorter woman have this much energy despite waking up in the middle of the night? Adora pulled the covers over her head, wondering if she should get up or stay in bed. Her sleep had been light, as if she hadn't gotten any rest at all. As the blonde drifted to sleep, someone yanked the blanket. Groaning, she peeked at Glimmer.

"Did you sleep?" Glimmer asked.

"Yes," Adora said. "What time is it? Usually, I'm an early bird. I hope I didn't waste half the day in here."

"Thirty minutes after nine."

Adora sat up and swung her legs over the edge of the bed. "I knew it."

Glimmer grabbed Adora's shoulders. "Don't rush yourself. By the way, how's the injury?" She scrutinized the bandages. "Does it hurt?"

Adora's fingers brushed the bandages. "Not as much as yesterday. What's everyone doing?" She observed the princesses and other rebels. "I want to help out."

"I'm sure you do. However, you won't be effective if you overwork yourself. The princesses and I can defend our hideout. For once, let others take care of you."

Glimmer and the princesses walked to the meeting table. Adora stretched her limbs for several minutes, then strode to a nearby mirror. She removed the bandages to check the wound. There were no signs of infection, and it had stopped bleeding. She was still frustrated with herself for freezing up yesterday. It could have been a trauma response. Was she as incompetent as Shadow Weaver said she was? Why was Adora relying on others to help her? The blonde was a hero, not a damsel.

Adora changed into her everyday clothes and grabbed her staff. The weapon wasn't as good as the Sword of Protection, a blade she had broken. It would be nice to cut the clones and bots into pieces. Sighing, Adora approached Glimmer and the princesses. Catra stood in the corner, watching them. As tempting as it would be to deck Catra again, Adora remained calm. Saving Etheria was more important than losing her cool. The magicat's ears flattened. Catra seemed tense. Adora must have been vibrating with anger.

"If you're anxious to beat me up, why don't you do it already?" Catra asked. "It's gonna be pointless, considering there are much bigger issues than bad blood. Horde Prime's destroying our home."

Adora exhaled audibly. As much as she hated to admit it, Catra was right. She should put her anger aside and wait until the war was over. Then, the Rebellion could do something about Catra.

She occupied a chair, ignoring the magicat. Mermista spoke of Sea Hawk's recent location. At the moment, he was in Salineas.

"I'll find him and remove the chip from his neck," Mermista said.

Adora placed her hands on the table. "I can help."

"Are you sure? You got hurt yesterday."

"The wound is better."

Glimmer cleared her throat. "Adora, if you want to help Mermista, you should be careful. I don't want something terrible to happen to you."

"I'm already careful," Adora said.

Glimmer held Adora's hands. "Come back safely. I'll watch over the hideout."

Within an hour, Adora, Mermista, and Perfuma were ready. They stepped out, embarking on a search for Sea Hawk. Would they succeed?

To Keep Her Safe

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora, Perfuma, and Mermista arrived in Salineas, searching for Sea Hawk. There was one problem - bots and clones patrolled the area. Adora gripped her staff, knuckles blanching. Not only did they have to worry about finding Sea Hawk, but they also had to prioritize getting out alive. She began missing She-Ra's strength. As soon as the emotion came, she suppressed it. There was no backing down. The three women hid behind a rock to evade the searching eyes of their enemies. A distant whir of a drone pierced the silence. Ocean waves crashed against the shore. The group should make a move soon. Adora hoped their plan would work. She peeked out from behind the rock, observing her foes. They seemed serious. A drone hovered in front of her, scanning the area. She rammed her staff into the drone, drawing the attention of clones and bots.

Mermista summoned water tendrils at the clones and bots, knocking them out. Perfuma's vines restrained the remaining clones. Adora led them to a waterside village. It was under Horde Prime's control. A few individuals trembled in fear of Horde Prime's cronies. The others, who were mind-controlled, told them to step into Prime's light. Adora, Perfuma, and Mermista hid from their sight.

"What do we do?" Mermista asked.

Adora stepped past the crates and watched the locals. "For starters, those with chips on their necks are obeying Prime against their will. People who don't have anything on their napes are hiding in their homes and avoiding everyone else. There are clones and bots on the streets." She glanced at the staff in her sweaty hands, swallowing the emotions that would hinder her. "I will sneak up to a clone and stab the back of its neck. It will draw

the attention of Prime's forces, but it will work. I'll catch them by surprise, ambushing them and taking them down. Perfuma will restrain the chipped individuals, and Mermista will use her water powers to defeat our enemies. Then, we'll find Sea Hawk."

"And you're confident the plan would work?" Mermista asked. "What if the clone catches you sneaking up on them? They could grab you!"

Adora gritted her teeth. "What do you expect me to do, sit on the sidelines and let you both do all the dirty work? I had years of fighting experience. I trained in the Horde. I was She-Ra until I broke the sword."

"We helped free you from Horde Prime's control, and you got attacked yesterday."

"Girls, do you have any better ideas?" Adora waited for her friends to respond. "Go ahead, tell me. I know you two have been concerned for my safety ever since you fought my chipped self. I may not have She-Ra, but I'm still a fighter."

Perfuma frowned as she clasped her hands together. "We don't want to lose you again. Glimmer was so determined to get you back that she would stop at nothing to save you. As for our plan to find Sea Hawk, we could improvise."

"You're right about us improvising," Adora said. "It's what we do best."

Within the next half hour, the group got busy freeing the village and fighting their enemies. They managed to save the chipped villagers from Horde Prime's control. Despite the challenges and exhaustion, they persisted. Adora, Mermista, and Perfuma found Sea Hawk in the town square. Perfuma summoned the vines to restrain him. Mermista approached her boyfriend and removed the chip from his neck. A static noise pierced the silence before the chip died out. Mermista held an unconscious Sea Hawk in her arms. Adora glanced around, watching for more foes. No danger

lurked in the vicinity at the moment. The new wound on her leg bled, and she let out a groan.

"Adora, what happened to your leg?" Perfuma asked.

"A drone attacked me," Adora said. "I'll be fine."

"Are you sure? It could be a serious injury."

The group began walking out of Salineas. Pain shot through Adora's affected leg with each step she took. A comm pad beeped, and she peeked at it. Perfuma was speaking to someone. Adora inched closer and looked at the screen. Her heart skipped a beat at the sight of Glimmer's smile. She had never gotten tired of seeing that grin. A thought crossed her mind; if Glimmer noticed the injury, the queen might start worrying. Adora knew how protective Glimmer could be sometimes.

"We got Sea Hawk. He's currently unconscious, and Mermista is carrying him," Perfuma was saying. "We freed a village, too. A drone hurt Adora."

"A drone what?" Glimmer asked. "How bad is it? Can Adora still walk? Do I need to get you guys?"

Adora held up her hands. "I'm fine, Glimmer. It's not bad, so stop worrying." She became aware of the weight she was putting on her wounded leg. "I'll be okay, really." Despite her words, a whimper escaped her lips.

"Adora…" Glimmer drew out the syllables.

"Okay, Glimmer. My leg is bleeding. Can you come to get us?"

"I'll be there in a second. Hold on!"

At the sound of a teleport, the screen went blank. Adora clutched her leg as she leaned against a tree. Mermista and Perfuma gazed in all directions, as if anticipating danger. Glimmer appeared. The queen teleported the group to the hideout. Mermista carried Sea

Hawk to an empty cot. Perfuma hugged Bow. Glimmer led Adora to their shared cot and examined the wound, brows furrowing. The queen's hands glowed.

"I haven't used the healing spell before, so hopefully it works," Glimmer said. "I'm glad you're okay. You guys saved Sea Hawk, and you freed a village. Those are some small victories." She healed Adora's leg. Once the wound was gone, she took care of the rest.

Adora shrugged. "I guess. However, I would have bigger victories if I still had She-Ra's power. I wish I had She-Ra's strength again."

Glimmer sat next to Adora. "Maybe it'll come to you when you least expect it."

"I suppose."

"Give it time."

Glimmer took Adora's hands, thumbs caressing knuckles. Adora's heart fluttered at the touch, and she couldn't help but stare into Glimmer's eyes. It was impossible to ignore the love in the queen's eyes. For a moment, no one was around. Just the hero and the queen, gazing at each other. Heat flooded Adora's face. A subtle blush highlighted Glimmer's cheeks. Both women's fingers intertwined.

"Adora… I love you," Glimmer said as she embraced Adora.

"Glim… I love you, too…" Adora whispered, wrapping her arms around Glimmer.

Adora had figured that the confession would come at some point, but did they have to do it during the war? When they weren't a hundred percent sure about making it out alive? She rested her chin on Glimmer's head, feeling the hairs tickle her chin. They had spent so much time together. Their friendship had survived rough patches. However, considering the confession, she wasn't sure how to refer to their relationship. Were they dating, or were they

love interests? She didn't have experience with romance, so it was new to her. Would it be like the relationship between Netossa and Spinnerella?

Adora pulled away. "I… I can't believe we… admitted our feelings to each other. There's still a lot going on in Etheria."

"I know," Glimmer replied. "At least we finally told each other." Her cheeks reddened. "Well, I'm going to check on our friends." She stood, then peeked over her shoulder. "Adora, you mean everything to me."

The queen proceeded to chat with the others. Adora couldn't ignore the lingering warmth in her heart as she replayed Glimmer's words in her mind. A smile tugged at her lips. She wanted to talk to Glimmer more. Perhaps later, when the queen wasn't busy checking on their friends. Adora placed her staff next to the mirror and caught her reflection. The red jacket, matching boots, white turtleneck shirt, and gray pants? It was her sole outfit. It was the same uniform she wore during her captivity on the Velvet Glove. As she thought about it, she began feeling self-conscious.

Adora released an audible sigh. Was there extra clothing in the hideout somewhere? Or was she stuck with the uniform? Shaking her head, she reminded herself to focus on significant things. She could try turning into She-Ra right now. Squeezing her eyes shut, she imagined herself transforming into the golden warrior. Adora murmured the signature transformation phrase. Yet, nothing came. She tried thinking about protecting her friends and keeping Etheria safe. Footsteps approached. Her eyes fluttered open. A small part of her expected to talk to Glimmer. However, she saw Catra standing by the crates. Was the magicat here to annoy Adora?

"What do you want, Catra?" Adora spat.

"Easy," Catra said, holding up her hands. "Anyways, I saw you and Glimmer flirting. You were having a lovey-dovey moment."

"So? Is it a problem? I love Glimmer with my whole heart."

"I don't see anything wrong with that. The two of you are meant for each other. Sparkles is so tender with you. Is it what drew you to her?"

Adora shifted her weight from foot to foot. As far as she could remember, Catra always had an ulterior motive during their past interactions. For some reason, the magicat seemed sincere. It could be a front. It wouldn't be any different from Shadow Weaver's manipulative behavior. Adora made eye contact, waiting for Catra to catch her off-guard. But the magicat didn't make a single move.

"Glimmer certainly has positive qualities," Adora said at last. "She's kind, loving, and protective."

"You know I'm trying to change, right?" Catra looked away before continuing. "I've spoken to Scorpia a few times. There seems to be a distance between us. I hurt her a lot in the past, even when we worked together in the Horde."

"I'm sure you must have hurt her. Did you apologize to Scorpia? I'm not talking about the apology you gave upon arrival."

Catra's ears lowered. "I did. Scorpia wasn't receptive."

Adora arched her brows. "Did you specify what you were sorry for? Or was it a one-word apology? You can't force someone to forgive you."

Catra's tail swished to one side. "I only said 'sorry.' I didn't specify what I apologized for."

"Have you tried specifying what you're apologizing for?"

"I suppose I could."

After the conversation ended, Adora rummaged her bag to see if there was a set of clothes other than her uniform. Her fingers met

something soft, and she pulled it out. It was a sky blue shirt, white leggings, and brown boots. She walked to a private area and changed her clothes. The shirt and leggings flattered her body. As for her ponytail, she adjusted it, allowing the bangs to frame her face. She would no longer have the signature 'hair poof' on her head. Adora made her way to her cot and sat down. There wasn't much to do in here.

Catra walked across the floor, Adora's words lingering in her mind as she approached Scorpia. The scorpioni woman and Entrapta were talking about Horde Prime's chips. Entrapta mentioned a plan to disable all chips at once. Horde Prime would be angry at the result, but did it matter? Etheria deserved peace and safety. Catra cleared her throat, alerting the two women to her presence.

"Hey, Scorpia," Catra said in a quiet tone.

"Hi," Scorpia replied.

Catra sighed. "Can we talk? I want to say something to you." She glanced at Entrapta. "Entrapta, can you give us some privacy?"

Entrapta smiled. "Yes. Don't take too long!"

Entrapta ran off, giggling. Catra and Scorpia made eye contact. Catra bit back a snarky comment about Scorpia spending time with the geeky princess. It wouldn't be wise to say who Scorpia should be friends with and who Scorpia should avoid. Scorpia was her own person. Catra took a deep breath.

Catra frowned. "I was so horrible to you. You had been so kind to me, even when I put up a wall around my heart. I was wrong to threaten you after I sent Entrapta to Beast Island. After the portal incident, I became meaner and pushed you away. One day, I had ranted at you, all because of some silly recordings. You were right to call me a bad friend. I want to make it up to you. Scorpia, you don't have to forgive me. Still, you deserved an apology. It's okay if you don't want us to be friends again."

Scorpia nodded. "I appreciate the apology. It'll take time for me to get past the hurt."

Before Catra could respond, Entrapta returned to the makeshift lab. "Entrapta, let everyone know when the plan is ready. I gotta go."

Catra strode to her cot and plopped onto the furniture. She had told Scorpia what she needed to say. Maybe the scorpioni woman would forgive her. Or, perhaps they wouldn't be friends again. Either way, she would be fine. She wouldn't be surprised if Scorpia befriended someone who would treat the tall woman with kindness and care. Catra reclined on her cot and stared at the ceiling. She thought about sneaking outside and doing something to alleviate her boredom. It didn't make sense in light of the war. If the clones and bots saw her again, they could start hunting her down. For now, Catra could work with the Rebellion. And once the Rebellion won, Glimmer would punish Catra for the magicat's crimes.

Within two hours of laying still, Catra heard a commotion. Her gaze followed the sound to the meeting table. Entrapta was telling everyone how she could disable all chips. Catra could imagine the enraged expression on Horde Prime's face in response to all his victims breaking free from his control. *Serves him right for being a tyrannical egomaniac,* she told herself.

"Entrapta, it could be a good idea," Adora was saying, "But how will you pull it off? There has to be a possible risk. Someone could get captured."

"The chips would fuse to their victims' nervous systems. We could run out of time if I don't cut off Prime's connection to the chips," Entrapta replied.

"And would it involve putting ourselves in more danger? I still don't have She-Ra."

"At least I would be helping in some way."

"Isn't there a safer way to do it?"

Catra continued listening to their conversation. The group had differing opinions regarding what Entrapta told them. A few princesses ended up taking sides. One side said Entrapta could proceed with the risky mission. The others pointed out the chances of things going wrong. Catra began to wonder how they survived the war despite the petty squabbles. Were they more stubborn than she thought? Thirty minutes passed. Glimmer spoke up, an action that seemed to quiet everyone.

Glimmer stood, straightening her back. "I know you all have opinions on this. We're trying to save Etheria, so we can't waste time arguing. Entrapta may not be a fighter, but her skills will be useful. All of us will work together, doing whatever we can. We won't let Prime control his victims any longer."

The others expressed agreement as they listened. Soon, Adora and Perfuma left with Entrapta. Catra swore she heard them mention a place with a high concentration of clones. Once the girls were gone, Glimmer sat at the table. Frosta and Mermista chatted by the crates. Catra wasn't sure what to do to diminish her boredom. Shadow Weaver would be unpleasant to speak to. Scorpia might not be interested in talking. Catra walked to the table. She could see tons of notes and a few maps. Then, she turned her attention to Glimmer.

"What would my punishment be?" Catra asked.

Glimmer looked up. "I didn't realize you were speaking to me."

"Oh. I was asking about my punishment."

Glimmer gathered the papers. "I'm still deciding on it. You've caused so much harm to people and set off the portal. The portal killed my mother and alerted Horde Prime to our existence. Recently, you've been acting different. You're not expecting anything from us in return, correct?" She wrote on empty papers. "You've always had hidden motives for making choices."

"I don't have any hidden motives this time. And I'm sorry about your mother." Catra occupied a chair and rested her elbows on the table. "What are you going to do to Shadow Weaver? She's a cruel and manipulative hag."

"I'll come up with something severe for Shadow Weaver," Glimmer said, anger lacing her tone.

"Would it be harsher than a magical prison?"

Glimmer nodded. "Of course."

Catra crossed her arms. "Knowing Shadow Weaver, she's not gonna learn a lesson. She's always been self-serving and power-hungry."

"Yeah. And Shadow Weaver taught my father magic."

"Didn't she also teach you magic? I once saw you holding hands in the Fright Zone."

"Shadow Weaver started teaching me spells after I became queen. Adora had expressed her concerns about it. It put a strain on my friendship with Adora. The arguments made it worse."

"When did you and Adora make it up to each other?"

"Adora and I exchanged apologies after I freed her from Prime's control."

"What was it like fighting a chipped Adora?"

Glimmer leaned back in her chair. "It was something I didn't want to do. I was angry at Horde Prime for controlling Adora. If I ever see him in-person, I'll make him pay for what he did to Adora."

Catra had seen a glimpse of how Horde Prime would fight. The galactic warlord must have battled other opponents in his past. It wouldn't be anything like fighting Hordak and Shadow Weaver.

Hordak was intense, while Shadow Weaver relied on magic. What would be Horde Prime's weakness?

"And what would you do to Horde Prime? Use magic on him?" Catra asked. "Adora tried to land a hit when she met him. He was quick to defend himself. Prime choked her with his tentacles, and I told him to spare her."

"Adora didn't use her powers due to breaking the sword," Glimmer said.

"Prime would have blocked the attack either way." Catra's ears flattened against her head. "He has to have a weakness. Everyone does, right?"

"He must be hiding it well to make himself appear invincible. Adora and I will still take him down."

"You and Adora are so determined. You two work so well together."

Glimmer chuckled. "I know." Her smile fell. "I keep thinking the clones would capture her again. It sounds dumb, considering that she has someone to protect her. And she can take care of herself. It's different without She-Ra."

"It's not dumb to worry about Adora's safety."

"Says the girl who hurt Adora a lot."

"That was the old Catra. The new Catra won't be mean to her."

Glimmer picked up a comm pad. The screen flashed to life, revealing Adora's face. "How's the mission going? Did Entrapta figure it out? Did you run into any clones or bots?"

Adora seemed shaken up. "I saw Horde Prime's hologram. He told Etherians to surrender to him. He says Etheria will suffer if the people refuse to bow to him. Also, the clones attempted to capture Entrapta." She glanced around before continuing.

"Entrapta's okay now. She figured out the technology. Perfuma's safe, too." She narrowed her eyes. "And is Catra sitting next to you?"

"The hologram must have scared you. How did the clones see Entrapta? Did she wander out of the hiding spot? As for Catra, we were talking about you."

"Entrapta stepped close enough for the clones to detect her. She tried to talk to Hordak. I swear she has a thing for him. Hordak stopped the clones from attacking Entrapta. It was surprising, as we know how cruel Hordak is."

Catra snorted. "I still don't get what Entrapta sees in Hordak. He's a jerk."

Adora furrowed her brows. "Perfuma, Entrapta, and I will return to the hideout soon."

Glimmer stormed through the castle hallway, fuming. The queen couldn't remember what angered her, but it must have been infuriating. Quiet voices penetrated the silence. The guards were whispering into each other's ears. Every word was clear. No matter how hard she tried, she couldn't ignore them. 'Weak princess.' 'Ineffective commander.' The worst insult of all? 'Queen of Failure.' How often had she begged Angella to let her go on dangerous missions with Adora and Bow? How often had Glimmer turned to Shadow Weaver for advice? She had tried her best to protect people, only to fail.

A few individuals snickered. Glimmer couldn't tell who was chuckling. Whoever they were, she assumed they were looking down on her. It wasn't surprising, as she had limited magic during her princess days. Most people didn't expect a pink princess to be a fighter. They often dismissed her. There wasn't any way she could prove them wrong. Or was there? As she entered the meeting room, a whoosh filled her ears as her surroundings blurred around her.

"It's too dangerous for you to go out there, Glimmer!"

"Stay in the castle where you belong!"

Everything faded to black. Images materialized in the darkness. No, memories of each shortcoming; yelling at her mother, learning magic from Shadow Weaver, blaming Adora for Angella's death, and screwing everything up. Glimmer waited for more memories to show up. Yet all she saw was empty blackness. A flash of green pierced the area. She blinked, and she found herself standing outside. Horde Prime's hologram spoke. However, she couldn't understand his words. A twig snapped; she peeked at the source of the sound. Adora wore a blank expression, eyes glowing green.

"She hoped you would come to your senses."

"Into the light…"

Glimmer prepared to respond. Adora swung the sword at her in a swift motion. As the weapon met Glimmer's leg, everything went dark. Sinister laughter echoed in her ears. She recognized the voice.

"You couldn't save your precious Adora…"

…

Glimmer opened her eyes. She became aware of something - or someone warm - nestled in her arms. Soft breathing drifted into her ears. Even without light, she recognized the sleeping form. Adora was here. The blonde wasn't in danger. Glimmer tucked a strand behind Adora's ear. She would do anything to keep Adora safe. Other parts of the dream stood out to her. They must have manifested as a result of her insecurities and failures. Pushing those thoughts aside, she focused on the proximity between herself and Adora. The blonde murmured something, then chuckled. At least Adora wasn't struggling with a nightmare. Maybe she was in the middle of a pleasant dream.

However, the happiness Adora must have experienced was temporary. The giggles transitioned into fearful whimpers. What happened in the dream? Did the blonde stumble into a scary situation? Was Horde Prime in the nightmare? Was any of it related to his hologram and Entrapta's close call?

Glimmer stroked Adora's hair, then moved her hand down the blonde's nape. Her palm stopped a few inches above Adora's scars. She began rubbing small circles. The soft caresses calmed the blonde.

"I'm here, Adora…" Glimmer whispered.

Adora buried her face in Glimmer's chest. The blonde mumbled something about feeling safe. Glimmer was glad she could make Adora feel secure. The queen hummed into the taller girl's ear. Adora emitted a quiet snore. It could be three in the morning at this point. Or four, perhaps. Adora said something that caught her attention.

"Mara… She-Ra…" Adora whispered.

Was Adora dreaming about She-Ra and Mara? What could Mara be saying to the blonde? Was Mara imparting any wisdom? Did they discuss She-Ra and how to awaken the power? Glimmer could ask Adora later. They needed to sleep. Glimmer's eyes fluttered shut. She inhaled the faint scent of sandalwood and patchouli. Heaviness blanketed her body, and an image flooded her vision…

…

At first, everything was blurry and white. Glimmer scanned her surroundings, trying to make sense of the area. Where was she? Stepping forward, she searched for something unusual. There was nothing of interest. Within seconds, a woman with wings and long hair materialized. It was her mother. Was Angella visiting Glimmer in the dream world? Or did her mind conjure the woman? Either way, she didn't think she would see her mother again.

"Mother? How are you here?" Glimmer asked.

"I have been watching over you, Glimmer," Angella said. "You make me proud."

"I wasn't a good queen. I activated the Heart of Etheria and brought Horde Prime to the planet. As a result, he took Adora and chipped her. She can't transform into She-Ra. I wish I could fix everything."

"We all make mistakes. You'd be surprised at the things I did at your age." Angella placed a hand on Glimmer's shoulder. "Your shortcomings don't make you a bad queen. You can move on from your mistakes or continue dwelling on what went wrong."

"I'll try to move on. I'll do my best as a queen."

Angella smiled. "I'm sure you'll do your best. One more thing… Don't be hard on yourself."

…

Glimmer awakened. The queen peeked at Adora's face. Snatches of conversations wafted into her ears. It must be time to get up, as she could tell the others were ready for the day. Adora's eyes opened.

"How did you sleep?" Glimmer asked.

"Good. You?" Adora replied.

"Same."

"I enjoy cuddling with you. It's so comforting."

"We have important things to do. After we save Etheria, we'll cuddle whenever we want."

Chapter End Notes

Comments/Kudos appreciated! 🙂

For the Honor of Grayskull

Adora sat cross-legged on the cot, fiddling with the staff in her hands. Glimmer and the princesses held a meeting again. Entrapta mentioned using a program to disable the chips. So far, everything had gone as planned. However, She-Ra was the missing element. There had to be hundreds of clones and bots in Horde Prime's army. Adora recalled speaking to Mara in the dream. Both women had a connection due to their She-Ra powers. They had discussed awakening She-Ra. Toward the end of the dream, Mara told her to avoid giving up. Adora rose to her height and walked to Entrapta's makeshift lab. Entrapta pressed a wire into the chip, pigtails drumming the keys. The screen lit up with codes and lines. Scorpia grabbed a seat and moved closer to Entrapta.

"Almost there," Entrapta said.

"Good to know," Adora said. A scene from a nightmare arose. "Last night, I dreamed about Horde Prime resorting to desperate measures."

Scorpia's eyes widened. "What was he doing?"

"There were green flames. The clones were attacking innocent people. The nightmare could be a warning."

Catra approached the women. "I guess it was too important to dismiss."

Adora whirled around. "Were you listening to our conversation?"

"I was walking by when you mentioned Horde Prime."

"Oh. Besides, Entrapta will turn off every chip at once."

Entrapta glanced over her shoulder. "It'll start as soon as possible."

Adora nodded, then strode to the exit. Staring outside, she weighed two options. First option? Leaving the hideout by herself. Second one? Staying put. The former made more sense than the latter. How would she do anything useful if all she did was remain in her comfort zone? Footsteps approached, interrupting her thoughts. She turned around. Glimmer scrutinized her body language. What did the queen think Adora would do, run off? Adora hadn't even stepped outside. Biting her bottom lip, she peered at the exit. An urge to tell Glimmer to avoid following her surfaced. She wanted to ask the queen to quit coddling her. After all, the blonde was the hero. Adora was the current She-Ra. Etheria couldn't survive without She-Ra.

"Are you going somewhere?" Glimmer asked.

Adora shifted from one foot to the other. "Glimmer, I need to do something. I could fight Horde Prime without She-Ra's powers. He and his army won't get away with conquering Etheria." She shook her head. "I can't idle around while he attacks our home and controls people. Prime could be backing us into a corner by now. And I bet he enjoys making all of us suffer."

Glimmer grabbed Adora's hand. "What you're saying is, you're going to rush into danger? Your power is still dormant. Horde Prime could kidnap you again. You can't do it on your own. We're all in this together. I can't handle losing you. I need you here."

A brief flashback of their conversation in the castle arose. During that night, Adora had begged Glimmer to stay. And now Glimmer was the one asking Adora to remain in the hideout. What if there was a risk? Would it matter either way? Adora didn't care if she died saving Etheria. Glimmer and their friends would be happy. Etheria would be safe. Everyone else's lives were much more significant than Adora's. Adora knew Glimmer meant well when telling her to stay. However, she was worried about Etheria. Why in the world should the blonde hide? Was there a genuine reason? She was no damsel. Stepping away, she gazed at her staff. She wouldn't let Mara's sacrifice be in vain.

"I won't go," Adora said at last.

"It would have been dangerous to go alone," Glimmer replied. "Something could happen."

I suppose. "Glim, you're right."

Agreeing to Glimmer's words would convince the queen to drop the topic. Adora didn't need anyone to chase her while she searched for Horde Prime. She could sneak out in the middle of the night. By then, everyone would be sleeping. The queen strode to the meeting table and occupied a chair. Adora set up a makeshift fighting dummy by the mirror. The blonde began training. She imagined herself battling Horde Prime. Adora would do whatever it took, She-Ra or no She-Ra. And she wouldn't allow anyone to hinder her.

Some might consider Adora reckless for facing Prime alone. What else could she do? Let people get hurt? As those thoughts continued flooding her mind, she hit the dummy harder. She became aware of the excited chatter. The princesses said that Entrapta succeeded in disabling the chips. Good. Horde Prime couldn't control his victims anymore. There was one thing yet to be done. Adora would defeat the galactic warlord.

"Are you okay? You seem frustrated," Glimmer said.

"I'm training," Adora replied.

"We could go on the mission together if you want."

Adora spun on her heel and made eye contact. "No. You can't. You're the queen! I'm the hero."

Glimmer lowered her eyebrows. "Adora, we're a team. You're not in this battle alone." Her voice was stern as she spoke. "Just because I'm the queen doesn't mean I can't join you. Didn't we discuss this before? You might be a hero, but you're not the only one saving the world. We're helping you. Entrapta has her tech. Bow has his arrows. The princesses and I have elemental powers.

We have saved you a few times." She took Adora's hand. "I promise to protect you, and I won't let any harm come to you."

"I appreciate your concern for my safety, and I know our friends helped out. However, I don't want any of you to get hurt," Adora said. "It doesn't matter what you say. I want to defend Etheria and vanquish Horde Prime. And I can't do it if I-"

"So, you'll throw your life away?"

Adora hesitated before speaking. "At this point, I would. At least Etheria will be at peace in the end. All of you will be happy."

Glimmer stared into Adora's eyes. "What about us? And you? Would you be okay with dying young? We confessed our feelings to each other a while ago."

"I know. But if I'm anything like Mara… I may sacrifice myself. Anyone who's chosen to be She-Ra…" Adora's voice trailed off as she recalled a hologram telling her to let go. "When I'm gone-"

"Adora, don't start."

"You could always find someone else. Each person who's destined to be She-Ra all ended their lives."

Glimmer reached for Adora's face, both palms brushing the taller woman's cheeks. Then, the queen wrapped her arms around Adora's neck, drawing the blonde closer. The next thing Adora knew, their mouths collided. Her pulse skipped a beat. There was passion in the way they kissed. Heat flooded her cheeks as she pulled away. Glimmer was blushing, too. Adora emitted a soft sigh. They just kissed for the first time. Warmth blossomed in her heart. A desire to kiss again overwhelmed her.

"It's how much I love you," Glimmer said.

"Glim…" Adora couldn't find the words. She swallowed a lump in her throat. "I…" She walked to her cot, sat down, and buried her reddening face in her hands.

Adora didn't deserve any of it. She didn't do well as a hero. Of all the girls in the Rebellion, Glimmer kissed her. Didn't the queen see how much of a screw-up she was? Adora was the same person who let Horde Prime chip her. Glimmer should be with someone who wasn't defective. Adora blinked back her tears as she sniffled. A palm caressed her shoulder, and she looked up. Glimmer's eyebrows drew together, and she pursed her lips.

"Did I make you uncomfortable?" Glimmer asked.

"No," Adora said. "I like the kiss. There's something on my mind. It's about a nightmare."

Glimmer occupied the empty space next to Adora and embraced her. "I guess it's another Horde Prime dream."

Adora rested her head on Glimmer's shoulder. "It is. I saw clones and green flames. A horrifying sight to behold. And the worst part of it all? I was too late to stop Horde Prime and his army."

Glimmer raked her fingers through Adora's hair and whispered into the taller woman's ear. It would be nice to stay in Glimmer's embrace, but Adora wasn't about to relax. Not until Horde Prime and his cronies were gone. She wasn't a vulnerable child who needed constant coddling. For a moment, though, she melted into the hug. She basked in the feeling of safety. Ten minutes dragged on. Both women released each other. Adora folded her hands in her lap and tapped her foot. She considered training harder.

"I enjoyed kissing you," Glimmer said.

"Same," Adora said.

Afternoon came. The princesses went on missions to free more villages and kingdoms from Prime's control. Glimmer pored over the maps, notes, and reports. Adora hadn't spoken to her since their last conversation. The blonde was hyper-focused on beating up the fighting dummy. Adora didn't take any breaks. Whenever anyone tried to talk to Adora, she would ignore them.

Occasionally, the blonde would give one-word answers. An hour earlier, she had cussed at Catra and told her to get lost. Glimmer found it surprising, as Adora and Catra hadn't gotten into any confrontations other than the magicat's arrival. Glimmer peeked at the map. The Princess Alliance had already freed half the planet. Their successes prompted Horde Prime's hologram to threaten Etheria. He said he would deal with She-Ra. It sounded like a threat. He could be plotting something horrible for Adora.

Glimmer gritted her teeth, rose to her height, and strode to her cot. Adora was still training. The blonde was panting. Sweat covered every inch of Adora's face and neck. Despite signs of exhaustion, Adora showed no indication of stopping. The dummy wobbled, close to falling over. Glimmer waited for Adora to notice her presence. Several minutes ticked by. Adora continued practicing. Glimmer made her way to the meeting table, muttering to herself. As she grabbed a chair, a voice garnered her attention. It was Catra.

"Did you try to talk to Adora?" Catra asked. "She's intense today."

"I did," Glimmer said. "She mentioned a nightmare. That's about it. She insisted on fighting Horde Prime on her own."

"She seriously considered a suicide mission?"

"Yeah. I'll keep a close eye on her."

"Adora wasn't kidding about you being protective of her." Catra grinned. "You two rub off on each other. It's obvious."

Glimmer snickered. "Adora and I certainly spend time together. Also, she can't keep ignoring everyone. There has to be a way to get her attention."

"And how would you do it? Invite her to a princess meeting?"

"Maybe. In the past, Adora would listen to me. Even if my girl tried to hide her fear with aggressive training, it wouldn't remove her unease. I bet in her mind, her anxiety would go away if she

solved everything on her own. I've seen how she responds to dangerous situations."

"She's a hero."

"A hero with emotions. Adora gets nervous sometimes. The Battle of Bright Moon was one such example." Glimmer crossed her arms. "Her fear must have escalated due to the nightmare."

Catra scrutinized her claws. "And you'll continue trying to get through to Adora?"

"Of course."

"Good luck with that."

Catra walked away before Glimmer could respond. Glimmer stared at the ceiling, losing herself in her thoughts. The queen remembered Adora's stories of the Horde. Adora once told her the Horde forbade any emotional expression. Her former superiors were okay with their soldiers displaying hatred toward enemies. Could Adora be reverting to how she used to handle emotions?

It was strange to think that the queen and the hero were once enemies. Even then, there was something different about Adora. Glimmer had found it impressive when Adora defended Thaymor from Horde soldiers. What would Adora have been like if she never joined the Rebellion? Would Adora have acted ruthlessly? Glimmer smiled as she dwelled on She-Ra's appearance. Sure, Adora and She-Ra were the same person. The latter resembled a warrior goddess. She-Ra's muscles were unforgettable. And the golden glow? It was a reminder that She-Ra was the beacon of hope.

Still, Glimmer loved Adora for who she was, not who she should be. The queen admired Adora's positive qualities. Her hero was kind and brave. Glimmer never tired of seeing the blonde's smile. Adora's lips were soft and kissable. She didn't regret their first kiss. Not one bit. She would do it again if the opportunity arose.

Night came. Adora and Glimmer slipped under the covers, limbs tangling as they held each other close. The blonde's heart raced as she took deep breaths. Adora would wait for Glimmer and everyone else in the hideout to fall asleep. Then, she would flee. The queen seemed content, cuddling with Adora. Adora would have to be careful not to awaken her later. Glimmer buried her face in Adora's chest.

Glimmer's breaths were long and gentle. The queen emitted a snore. Adora didn't move a muscle. It wouldn't be wise to act too soon. Typically, someone would descend into deep sleep after an hour. However, the minutes crawled at a snail's pace. Adora shut her eyes in case Glimmer peeked at her. Her mind kept her awake with every thought. Where would she confront Horde Prime? In the Fright Zone? The Velvet Glove? The location didn't matter. She couldn't wait to get this done with. Silence blanketed the hideout. Glimmer's exhales and inhales drifted into her ears. Sleepiness threatened to drag Adora into dreamland. Shaking her head, she resisted the pull of slumber.

Glimmer rolled onto her back, mumbling something. The queen didn't stir awake. Adora slipped out of bed, footsteps silent as she changed her clothes and picked up the staff. Her gaze flitted around. Although it was dark, she was sure no one was moving. Stepping outside, she took one last look at the entrance. She broke into a run, speeding past the trees. Flashes of her capture arose. Despite the danger, she wouldn't turn back. Panting, she stumbled into a clearing. Was there any way to know where Horde Prime was? Or did she have to let him abduct her? It was risky either way. A rustle of the bushes spiked her adrenaline. She widened her stance, bracing for an ambush. A twig snapped. The whir of a drone pierced the cold air. Clones and bots emerged, pointing their weapons at her.

Adora evaded a beam and charged at the nearest clone. She plunged the staff into his chest, rendering him unconscious. A bot unleashed a laser, slicing across her leg. She suppressed a yelp and lunged at the drone. A clone restrained Adora's arms from behind. She drove her heel into their foot and rammed an elbow

into their side. The action forced them to release her. Tightening her grip on the staff, she stabbed her attacker's abdomen. Dozens of lasers grazed the ground near Adora. She jumped out of the way. Horde Prime's soldiers were delaying the inevitable. Holding up her hands, she watched the clones and bots. Once they noticed the gesture, they paused.

"Take me to Horde Prime," Adora said.

"You will go to him, She-Ra," a clone said.

"I will fight Prime to the death. Take me to where he is."

"You dare challenge our leader? Your defiance is futile."

Two clones flanked Adora as they escorted her out of the clearing. She hoped she would awaken her power soon. As they strode through the woods, every memory arose. Dread settled in her stomach. Now wasn't the time to retreat. The comfort zone was for weak individuals. She was a hero, not a wimp. Her captors discussed Horde Prime cleansing Etheria. It would never happen. She would defeat Prime.

"Sparkles, wake up," a familiar voice whispered into Glimmer's ear. "Adora left."

Glimmer yawned as she narrowed her eyes at Catra. The queen became aware of the empty spot on the bed. Was it a dream? Did it happen for real? She glimpsed the pillow next to hers. Adora was here earlier. A part of her hoped the blonde girl was using the restroom. Also, if Catra was awake during Adora's departure, why didn't the magicat stop her?

"Is it a joke?" Glimmer asked as she glowered into Catra's eyes. "Because I don't find it funny at all."

"I'm serious," Catra said. "Adora's on her own."

"You better not be tricking me. Wait a minute…" Glimmer's feet met the floor. "Adora ran away, didn't she?" She rubbed her eyes. "We'll tell the princesses. We're not letting this slide."

"Are we going on a midnight mission?"

"We are."

Glimmer awakened the princesses and initiated an emergency meeting. She informed them of Adora sneaking off. Her friends complained about being awake at midnight. What did they expect the queen to do, avoid telling them? They would worry if she left without warning. After the conversation, she put on her armor and grabbed her staff. Glimmer, Catra, Bow, and the princesses walked into the woods. The group split up, searching the forest in multiple directions. What if the clones captured Adora? What happened to the blonde? Was Adora still alive? Did she find Horde Prime? Glimmer growled under her breath. For all she knew, Prime could be torturing Adora. An explosion echoed, and she summoned her magic.

"Fuck Horde Prime!" Glimmer spat as she unleashed a barrage of spells at clones and bots.

Bow, Catra, and the princesses attacked their enemies. Arrows, vines, water tendrils, wind gusts, and nets bombarded each foe. Frosta pummeled the drones with ice fists. Catra's claws gashed the clones. Glimmer expelled purple beams from her palms, demolishing Prime's soldiers. More and more foes advanced. How many were in Horde Prime's army? A wave slammed into their enemies, knocking them backward. Perfuma's vines restrained them. A hologram materialized, towering over the land. Horde Prime's eyes burned with murderous rage.

Horde Prime scowled. "You Etherians have forced my hand. I shall cleanse the planet of its rebellious inhabitants. Whoever disabled all those prototypes will pay. Your weak queen and her feeble friends think they can protect She-Ra from me. She-Ra has challenged me to a fight. I will slay your beacon of hope. She

won't stand a chance. You might as well tremble before me. I am the undefeatable ruler of the universe. I will make Etheria anew. None of you will be here!"

The hologram vanished. Horde Prime had confirmed Glimmer's suspicions. Adora was in grave danger. Glimmer led her friends through the forest, battling clones and bots. She needed to know where Adora went. They arrived at the edge of the woods. She conjured a location spell. An image of the Fright Zone surfaced.

"The Fright Zone," Glimmer said. "Adora's in there."

Catra snorted. "I assumed he would want to fight her in the Velvet Glove."

"The clones are guarding the headquarters."

"Let me guess. The plan is to charge in and rescue the hero. You tried it before."

"I'm a powerful queen now." Glimmer straightened her spine to emphasize her point. "I don't have to worry about limited sparkles."

Catra smirked. "Playing the hero, aren't you?"

"Damn right, I will be a hero for Adora! I'd do anything for my love!"

"Then what are you waiting for?"

"Let's save Adora!"

Adora stood before Horde Prime. The warlord's gaze combed over her. Flashing a sinister grin, he stepped closer. Fury darkened his eyes. Despite his subtle anger, he didn't yell or become violent. He lifted an icy palm to her cheek. She wanted to throw up. Instead, she settled for words.

"This ends now," Adora said as she shoved Prime's hand away. "You took over Etheria. You chipped me and other people. Horde Prime, you'll pay for your crimes."

"You won't be much of a challenge," Horde Prime said. "You haven't awakened your powers without my help." He motioned to the walls. "This used to be your home, correct? My little brother led a pathetic army to its unfortunate fall. Etheria is an ancient planet with a familiar technology. She-Ra, you grew up in his stronghold. One day, you joined the pesky Rebellion. A certain kitty informed me of a superweapon residing within Etheria. You could have been the key. You were under my control. And yet you allowed the queen to whisk you into the darkness." There was a growl in his voice as he spoke. "I will vanquish the rebellion, starting with you."

"I never consented to you chipping me," Adora said. "You forced me against my will. And you won't use the Heart of Etheria."

"You are foolish to believe you can defy me. I will dash the hopes of the Rebellion. You will fail. The ones you swore to defend will perish, and you won't be there to rescue them. What will you choose? A crushed uprising, or my empire? Surrender, or you will lose your life. I have faced many others similar to you. One of them hid the planet, did she not?"

"My friends and I haven't lost. We're pushing back. I won't surrender."

Horde Prime's scowl deepened. "You have chosen a harsh demise. Remain in the darkness, then." His fingers extended into tentacles with sharp ends. "See if you can hold your own."

Adora swung the staff in an attempt to land a strike. Horde Prime evaded the weapon, moving quickly. All she touched was air. Prime's tentacles launched forward. The blonde ducked them and charged at the warlord. His tentacles pinned Adora to the floor, sharp ends sinking into her flesh. Horde Prime's hair tubes

lengthened. Adora's heart leaped into her throat as she struggled to break free. He threw his head back, cackling.

Adora shot up to her height. "What on Etheria is so funny?"

"You are a weak opponent. How pitiful," Horde Prime said.

"Screw you." Adora lifted her empty hand upward. "For the honor of-"

Horde Prime's hair tubes wrapped around Adora's wrists and yanked her closer. He snatched the staff. It broke in his grasp. This action had consequences. The next thing Adora knew, she lay on the floor, unarmed. Prime circled her like a predator cornering its prey. Adora's friends would be disappointed if she lost. The warlord was clearly enjoying his advantage. She glared at him.

"Ooh, She-Ra is bitter over her inevitable loss," Horde Prime said. "Defiance will worsen things for you and Etheria. Why don't you return to the light, little sister? Be my soldier once more. You have sought out your family. Why not join mine? I gave you a belonging and a purpose. Your so-called friends don't want you. And they're not coming for you." He extended a hand to Adora. "Abandon those who have caused you pain."

Adora's breath lodged itself in her throat. Tears blurred her vision as the words replayed in her mind. She had always wanted to belong somewhere. Questions about family had haunted her for months. Even as a child, she longed for a parent who would love her unconditionally. Shadow Weaver had never been nurturing. Angella was like a mother, though. Adora made eye contact. Nothing Horde Prime said would convince her to capitulate.

"I won't abandon my friends," Adora said. "I don't want to be a mindless soldier for an evil empire."

Horde Prime shook his head. "What a waste of an asset. I will rule the universe without you."

In a swift motion, Horde Prime gripped Adora's neck and lifted her off the floor. Adora pounded his forearms and kicked his legs. The warlord didn't budge. She rammed her fist into Horde Prime's nose. Prime squeezed tighter, forcing the air out of her lungs. She drove her foot into his abdomen, eliciting a groan from him. He dropped her, grimacing.

Adora stood, rubbing her neck as she gawked at Horde Prime. Should she retrieve the broken staff? Should she try to transform into She-Ra again? Prime closed the distance between himself and Adora. Looming over her, he bared his teeth. Stiffening her posture, she gave him an intense stare.

"You should have left Etheria alone," Adora said.

"Etheria is mine," Horde Prime replied. "You're in the way. But not for long."

"You and your army are not welcome in Etheria. I will take you down!"

"And how will you fight me?"

Adora launched a fist at Horde Prime. He blocked the blow. She swung her other hand. Same result. She attempted to kick his groin. His tentacles wrapped around her ankle. Prime's hair tubes snaked around her neck and began squeezing. A teleportation chime pierced the air. Did Glimmer come? A purple sphere slammed into Horde Prime's spine. He released Adora and turned to face whoever attacked him.

"Get your hands off my girl!" Glimmer shouted.

Adora arched her brows in surprise. Did the queen follow her? Were Catra, Bow, and the princesses in the headquarters, too? Horde Prime charged at Glimmer and expelled his tentacles at her. She teleported, then reappeared by Adora's side. Prime roared in sheer rage, stormed toward the women, and shoved Glimmer to the wall. The queen fell to the floor.

"I won't let you hurt Glimmer!" Adora spat as she sensed her power awakening. "FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!"

A golden glow enveloped Adora. The white and gold uniform accentuated her torso. Its half-skirt billowed in the invisible breeze, and the leggings emphasized her legs. Her ponytail flowed out behind her. A slender blade rested in her hand. Its cross-guard formed a crescent moon shape. The tiara resembled Glimmer's. It had a red gem in front. Wings appeared on She-Ra's boots.

After the War

Adora charged at Horde Prime and slashed his side. The warlord bellowed in agony before recovering. He dodged her blows and shot tentacles at the hero. Their sharp ends collided against her, pinning her to the floor. They bit into her skin, drawing blood. A teleportation chime caught her attention. So did a purple beam. The magic forced Horde Prime to release Adora. Glimmer stood between them, shielding Adora. Wings emerged from the queen's back. Adora gazed at Glimmer in awe. The queen blasted the warlord with a barrage of spells, forcing him to step away.

"I won't let you lay a hand on my Adora!" Glimmer bellowed. "As long as I live, you will not destroy her!"

"How ridiculous. A feeble queen defending her precious hero," Horde Prime said.

Adora stood. So did Horde Prime. She-Ra's sword sliced the air. Tentacles blocked the strike. Glimmer slammed her hands together, emitting a bright flash. Horde Prime ducked the beam, chuckling. Purple orbs sped toward him. He sidestepped each time, hurrying closer. Adora sprung at him and brought down her sword. The blade's tip gashed Prime's leg. He picked up the broken staff and parried incoming blows. Their weapons clashed. Both struggled to gain the upper hand. Horde Prime drove his foot into Adora's abdomen. The impact sent Adora flying across the room.

Glimmer zipped through a pocket dimension. The queen reappeared above Horde Prime. She traced a rune in the air and unleashed it. The spell knocked Horde Prime off his feet. Another teleport, and she appeared a few feet away. Horde Prime held his weapon aloft and advanced. Adora leaped at him from behind. He whirled around and blocked the attack. She spotted an opening. In one motion, her sword nicked his forearm. Prime's hair tubes lengthened into metallic cords. Adora sidestepped the tentacles. Two caught her wrists. Another one snaked around her neck.

"Leave Adora alone!" Glimmer shouted as she expelled a powerful beam.

"Shut up!" Horde Prime retorted as he released Adora.

Glimmer shot a kinetic blast at Horde Prime's abdomen. "Fuck you, chalk-face!"

Horde Prime fell onto his back. Within seconds, he forced himself up. "It'll take more to defeat me. I shall reduce Etheria to rubble! And I will reign supreme!"

Adora tightened her grip on the sword. "No, Horde Prime. The galactic empire will crumble!" She lunged at Prime. The blade met his chest, carving a bloody line. "You're not the ruler of Etheria. People have suffered under your tyranny. You are an egotistical jerk!" She continued attacking her enemy. "I'll protect Glimmer, my friends, and the rest of Etheria from you!" Shaking with fury, she glared at Horde Prime. "Any last words?"

Horde Prime unleashed every tentacle at Adora's neck, wrists, and ankles, restricting her movements. He threw her at the wall. Adora groaned as she rose. Was the warlord that desperate to win? A feral scream drilled into her ears. Glimmer sprung at Horde Prime and blasted him with her magic. Horde Prime swung the staff at the queen. Glimmer teleported. He tried again. She continued evading his blows. Prime roared in frustration as he attempted to catch her. His tentacles met air. Just then, Glimmer rammed a wing into his body. Horde Prime lay on his back again. The queen's wings unfurled to full length as she stared at him. For a moment, Adora expected Glimmer to wallop the warlord. Glimmer rolled her fingers into angry cannonballs.

"It's over. You lost," Glimmer said, summoning her staff. "And woe to those who hurt my girl."

The queen plunged the staff into Horde Prime's chest. Glimmer twisted the weapon deeper. She beckoned Adora closer. The blonde stabbed the warlord's side. Horde Prime coughed as he

glowered at the women. Despite his defeat, his eyes burned with determination. He flashed an evil grin. Laughter erupted from his mouth before fading to wheezes.

"Insolent… brats…" Horde Prime said between gasps.

Glimmer's hands lit up with magic and surged the spell into Horde Prime's body. Adora's own glow entered the warlord. A flash of white light penetrated the room. The next thing Adora knew, a pile of ashes lingered. Horde Prime was no more. The queen and the hero descended to their knees, exhilarated and drained. Etheria would know peace at last. There wouldn't be any further war and bloodshed. Adora and Glimmer exchanged a look. A mix of relief and sternness mingled in the queen's violet eyes.

"You ran off in the middle of the night. At least you turned into She-Ra," Glimmer said. "Adora… we won. Still, if I hadn't arrived in time, you would be dead right now."

"I'm sorry for scaring you," Adora said.

"You know what? I'm not mad." Glimmer smiled. "Besides, we saved the world." She hugged Adora. "Let's tell everyone the news."

"Glim… your wings are beautiful. And they make you seem more powerful."

"I seem powerful, huh?" Glimmer thrust out her chest. "After all, I'm a strong queen." She grabbed Adora's hand. "Then again, I couldn't have done this without you."

Adora grinned as she stood. She helped Glimmer up, and they strode into the hallway. Remnants of broken bots cluttered the corridor. The clones were comatose. It was utter chaos in the Fright Zone. Puddles of water darkened parts of the metallic floor. Mermista and Frosta must have been here. Did the other princesses also storm the Fright Zone? Where were they now? Were they waiting outside? Adora and Glimmer stepped outside. Bow and the princesses wore relieved expressions. Catra's face

was void of emotion. Adora couldn't tell how the magicat was feeling.

"I'm ready to face my punishment after everything I've done," Catra said.

"There will be a tribunal soon," Glimmer said.

One morning, everyone gathered around a stage in Bright Moon. Hordak, Catra, and Shadow Weaver were in chains. As for Kyle, Lonnie, Rogelio, and Scorpia, they would perform community service for up to two years. They would help rebuild towns and homes. Hordak, Catra, and Shadow Weaver, on the other hand…

Glimmer glared at Shadow Weaver. "You are guilty of aggression against the land. Your imprisonment of me has taken away my powers for a brief time. You attempted to seize the Bright Moon throne. Also, you abused Adora and Catra when they were children. As a punishment, the sorcerers will restrict your powers."

Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes. "They can't take away my magic. I raised Adora and Catra to be strong. I could have maintained my connection to the Black Garnet if a rat hadn't severed it!" She glowered at Catra, then at Hordak. "Hordak allowed Entrapta to tinker with the runestone."

Catra grimaced. "How dare you call me a rat! You're a fucking bitch! You're bitter because I shattered that jewel on your mask!"

Glimmer held up a hand. "Silence, Catra." She turned her attention to Shadow Weaver. "A skiff will transport you to Mystacor. The guards will keep you under close watch. They won't allow you anywhere near Adora and the others you've hurt."

The guards took Shadow Weaver to a skiff. Within seconds, the vehicle left. Catra stepped forward, anger smoldering in her eyes. The insult must have struck a nerve. Had Shadow Weaver called Catra a 'rat' in the past? It wouldn't be surprising if the old sorceress did. Shadow Weaver had always been cruel to Adora

and Catra. When both girls were children, Adora was the golden child. Catra was the scapegoat.

"Catra, you have pleaded guilty to serious crimes. Aggression against the land, attempted omnicide, and activated the portal that alerted Horde Prime to Etheria's existence. You abused friend and foe alike. You helped Hordak conquer Etheria. The interdimensional portal killed my mother. All you did was make everyone suffer. However, you are capable of doing better. Apologizing to Adora and the others. Telling Horde Prime to spare Adora on the Velvet Glove. The tribunal took into account your upbringing and your dangerous past behavior. Your sentence may not be harsh, but the guards will watch you closely. They will catch you if you try to flee. Two times a week, you will attend therapy sessions. For ten years, you will help repair the damage you caused."

"Am I gonna be working all day every day?" Catra asked.

Glimmer's tone remained stern as she spoke. "Etherians won't forget what you've done. Don't expect them to forgive you easily. Catra, you will make bricks and other materials for rebuilding towns. Don't slack off in your work. You must make better choices in life."

"Damn right," Adora whispered, standing by the steps.

"Catra, your work starts now," Glimmer said.

The guards escorted Catra away. Hordak stepped forward. Mermista glowered at him from afar. Perfuma, Frosta, and Adora scowled. Entrapta furrowed her brows, frowning. Her pigtails lowered. Glimmer stiffened her posture, clenching her jaw. Hordak had caused years of suffering to Etheria. No matter what Entrapta said about him, he would face consequences.

"Hordak, you have pleaded guilty to aggression against the land, including attacks on kingdoms. The destruction of Salineas is the most egregious. By summoning Horde Prime to Etheria, you have

forced us to defend ourselves against a galactic empire. It has resulted in Adora's capture. There was an entire generation of Etherians who never knew peace. So many lives lost. So many were injured. Driven from their homes, too. Young children stolen from their families and raised into ruthless soldiers."

"That is true," Hordak said.

"Do you accept the consequences for what you've done?"

"Yes."

"Entrapta has informed me of your circumstances. Apparently it is the reason behind your actions."

"Prime cast me out for not achieving his view of perfection. I thought conquering Etheria would earn me a higher place in his army. However, I was wrong. He tried to make me into a mindless soldier. I had considered conquest noble. I had turned my troops into those who feared disobeying my orders. Eventually, I met someone who told me that imperfect beings mattered. Entrapta helped me realize I have worth. Gaining Prime's blessing ceased to be a goal for me. Entrapta's friendship is all that matters to me."

Glimmer nodded, taking in Hordak's words. She then glanced at Entrapta. "Princess Entrapta of Dryl, you consider him a friend? How do you view his crimes?"

Entrapta clasped her hands together. "I consider Hordak a friend. He understood me when no one else did. I'm aware of his crimes. I know what he did was wrong. Just don't be harsh on him."

"Give me one reason why not."

"While trying to figure out the technology in a place with many clones, I got too close. The clones saw me and tried to attack. Hordak pushed them back. I was close to saying something when Perfuma and Adora took me to safety."

"One good act cannot erase everything he did." Glimmer looked at Hordak. "The suffering you inflicted was immense. You are sentenced to ten years of labor. You will oversee the reconstruction of Salineas. All your plans must be approved by Princess Mermista, who will have ultimate authority. You are banned from owning weapons and working in a military."

The guards escorted Hordak to a vehicle. Once the tribunal ended, everyone went home. Glimmer strode into Bright Moon Castle. Adora accompanied the queen in the hallway. Both women made eye contact.

"I still can't believe the war is over," Adora said. "However, I keep expecting bad things to happen." She sighed. "It sounds unreasonable in light of our victory."

"Adora, it'll take time," Glimmer replied. "You're not the only one who feels this way. I don't want this to turn out to be a dream. We've gone through so much. We lost some people."

"Yeah. I had a nightmare about the war last night."

Glimmer held Adora's hand. "We could start going to therapy soon. I could cuddle you every night to keep the nightmares away."

Adora's cheeks flushed. "Sure. And I could never get tired of cuddling. Your hugs make me feel safe."

"I could say the same about your hugs." Glimmer embraced Adora, holding her tight. "We could stay like this." She buried her face in Adora's chest. "You'll always be my girl."

Adora stroked Glimmer's hair. "I'm definitely your Adora."

Glimmer's wings draped over both women. The queen lost herself in the intimate moment. Warmth flooded her senses as she remained still. The scent of sandalwood and patchouli wafted into her nose. She could feel the strength in Adora's arms. Her girlfriend's touch was also gentle. After what seemed like forever,

Glimmer stood on her tiptoes and leaned in for a kiss. Her mouth met Adora's.

Glimmer pulled away. "I love kissing you."

"Same," Adora said.

Adora strode through the hallway. Footsteps echoed off the walls as she approached a door. The blonde couldn't shake off the sense that someone was following her. Reminding herself to relax, she gripped the handle. It was cold to the touch. Whispers pierced the silence as she opened the door. The temperature sank. Shivering, she walked outside. A green glow enveloped the area. The next thing she knew, she stood before a throne. Horde Prime smirked at her. He rose, then advanced. Adora attempted to summon She-Ra. She didn't transform into the golden warrior. Horde Prime chuckled in amusement as he rested an icy palm on her cheek. Adora tried to speak. No words came. What was going on? Why couldn't she talk? Dread washed over her. Horde Prime loomed closer, his face filling her vision. His eyes narrowed. Static drilled into her ears. Prime's mouth moved, but his speech was unintelligible. Every syllable jumbled together.

Adora blinked. The entire scenery shifted. Horde Prime wasn't here. She found herself in a Horde locker room. A tall silhouette emerged. How did she get here? Did Shadow Weaver kidnap her? Trembling, Adora straightened her spine. The sorceress stopped in front of her, glaring. Shadow Weaver's palm brushed Adora's jaw. Goosebumps pebbled the blonde's body as she shuddered. The stench of alcohol lingered in the air. Was the older woman drinking again? Shadow Weaver spoke in drunken gibberish. How would Adora get out of this room? As she peeked at the exit, the witch grabbed her face with both hands. She swore she heard herself whimpering.

Everything around Adora changed. She gazed across a battlefield. Villages and trees were burning. Smoke obscured the sky. Catra appeared, grin widening. Half the magicat's body was pitch-black.

The magicat's claws extended. Adora whirled around and started to leave. Catra gripped her wrist. The blonde stared at Catra, frozen to the spot.

"Where are you going… failure? You are the weakest She-Ra ever!" Catra said in a distorted voice. "You can't save anyone… not even your precious girlfriend!"

A glitching Glimmer materialized. The queen wailed in agony. Thunder roared in the sky. Adora reached for Glimmer. The shorter woman vanished. A metallic flicker caught Adora's attention. She glimpsed the broken Sword of Protection. Disembodied laughter penetrated the air. Catra crouched in front of her, flashing a deranged smile.

"Everything bad that happened… It's all your fault! The disaster at Princess Prom. Almost losing the Battle of Bright Moon. Letting me touch your sword with a corrupted disk. Getting captured. Failing to take the sword in the portal. Breaking the Sword of Protection. And allowing Horde Prime to chip you!"

Adora couldn't take it anymore. She tried to block out the taunting. The words kept coming through. Catra laughed maniacally and scratched her. Everything went black. All she knew was an impenetrable darkness.

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Adora jerked awake, sobbing. Images of the nightmare lingered. She glimpsed the outlines of furniture in the room. Moonlight streamed into the window. Taking deep breaths, she peeked at Glimmer. The queen was sleeping. Glimmer mumbled a few words, then said something about the Horde. Perhaps the shorter woman had a nightmare, too. Adora tucked a strand behind Glimmer's ear and caressed her girlfriend's cheek. The blonde slipped out of bed and walked to the window. It was a clear night. Tiny pinpricks of light twinkled in the inky blackness. It was a serene sight to behold. Adora sat down and leaned against the window. The dream faded from her mind. Would therapy help

with those dreams? Or would she remember the emotional wounds forever? Footsteps approached, garnering her attention.

"Couldn't sleep?" Glimmer asked, yawning.

"I guess. How about you?" Adora replied.

"Same. The nightmare woke me up."

"Those dreams can jump off the cliff for all I care." Adora folded her hands in her lap. "I dreamed about Horde Prime, Shadow Weaver, and Catra. The first two touched my cheeks. Catra attacked me."

Glimmer sat next to Adora. The queen rested her head on the blonde's shoulder. "At least we don't have to see Horde Prime and Shadow Weaver. After all, Horde Prime lost. I made sure Shadow Weaver won't hurt you again." She wrapped her arms around Adora's waist. "You're here, safe and sound."

"Glim… I'm so thankful for you," Adora said. "I love you so much, my brave queen."

"I love you too, my gorgeous hero." Glimmer played with Adora's blonde strands. "Do you know how amazing you are?"

Adora smiled at the question. "Yeah, I'm amazing. It comes with being She-Ra."

"I'm sure it does." Glimmer tapped Adora's nose. "Also, I like your smile."

"Thanks. Yours is adorable, too."

"Aww, you're so sweet." Glimmer looked outside. "It's still dark out. You want to go back to bed?"

"Of course."

Glimmer teleported herself and Adora to their bed. Both women reclined. They pulled the covers over their bodies. Adora's eyes fluttered shut. Glimmer drew her closer. The queen's wings blanketed both women. Warmth washed over Adora. The scent of lavender made her forget her worries. Gentle hums drifted into her ears. As time whizzed by, she sank into a deep slumber.

The next thing Adora knew was the sensation of light on her eyelids. There was a yawn. Aware of Glimmer's embrace, she nuzzled her face into the queen's chest. She lacked a desire to get out of bed. And the fact that their cuddles were cozy… She wanted to stay in bed all day long. Yet she couldn't. At some point, she would have to get up. Her girlfriend had to attend to royal responsibilities. Adora opened her eyes and rolled onto her back. Glimmer sat up, then grinned at her.

"How did you sleep?" Glimmer asked.

"I slept good," Adora said. "How's yours?"

"Same."

A knock on the door interrupted their conversation. Someone mentioned Glimmer's royal duties. The queen changed her clothes and left the room. Adora wished their moment lasted longer. Then again, they could see each other whenever Glimmer wasn't working. Adora got dressed and walked into the hallway. She wandered toward a window. Occasionally, the guards would chat. There wasn't anything interesting.

As wonderful as it was, the peace seemed unreal. A part of Adora expected the other shoe to drop. Was there anything to do in a world without war? She wasn't the type of person to relax. Gazing outside, she watched the clouds glide across the sky. A gardener tended to the flowers in the courtyard. A few trees swayed in the breeze. Footsteps moved closer, drawing her attention. Micah was standing by the door.

"Hello," Micah said.

"You want to talk to me, sir?" Adora replied.

"Yes. And I've heard you've been dating my daughter. What is something that drew you to Glimmer?"

"I've already mentioned her bravery." Adora recalled Glimmer extending a hand to her in Thaymor. "Glimmer was willing to give me a chance after I left the Horde. I lived in the castle ever since."

"And you became friends first?"

"Of course. We were close. Glimmer and I were affectionate with each other. We would hug, hold hands, and cuddle. Glimmer saved me sometimes. Once, Glimmer teleported out of magical binds and punched Shadow Weaver. Although risky, she didn't want Shadow Weaver to erase my memories. Glimmer's powers started glitching. I took her out of the Fright Zone. Later, Angella healed Glimmer. One time, when Catra held me hostage, Glimmer stormed the Horde Headquarters. She tried to rescue me. Catra quickly activated the portal. We did get out of there. Angella didn't make it. Glimmer couldn't process her grief upon taking the throne. We argued a lot. The night I broke the Sword of Protection, Horde Prime kidnapped me. It didn't take long for him to chip me and control me. Soon, I returned to Etheria. Glimmer found me in the woods and fought me. Because of her words, I broke free. If not for her, I wouldn't be here."

"Glimmer cares about you so much."

Adora nodded. "True. Glimmer is protective of me. Well, we protect each other."

"Do you see yourself having a future with my daughter?"

Adora hesitated as she pondered the question. She imagined her future self. Her mind drifted to Glimmer. A thought of a wedding arose. Maybe she could marry Glimmer someday. If the relationship went well, both women could tie the knot.

"Yes," Adora said at last. "Glimmer and I are compatible. There's mutual respect. I can't imagine my life without her."

"It sounds like the two of you won't have a problem spending your lives together as a couple. You'll be a wonderful spouse to Glimmer someday."

Adora smiled at Micah's words. She would do her best to be a great partner to Glimmer. Micah left the hallway. Adora strode through the corridors and proceeded into the courtyard. The blonde occupied a bench by the rosebush. A warm breeze rustled through her hair. She gazed at the land surrounding Bright Moon. Clouds, woods, the mountains, and the water… The aroma of flowers and beautiful greenery…

Adora could sit here all day. Despite the tranquility, she couldn't deny the growing anxiety within her. Her pulse began racing. The next thing she knew, images of dangerous situations arose. Heat suffocated her body as she fought to control her breathing. Every memory surfaced, each one worse than the last.

Dark spots blurred the edges of Adora's vision. She shot up to her height. The ground came up to meet her. She couldn't think or move. Speaking was out of the question. Her lungs and throat constricted. Was she dying? The mere question seemed to make things worse for her. She barely registered a voice repeating her name. Someone rolled her to her back. It was Glimmer. Wasn't the queen busy?

"Adora, breathe," Glimmer said. "Count to ten. Slowly."

Adora counted to ten. Within seconds, her breathing and heartbeat slowed. She sat up. The queen caressed her arms. Glimmer embraced Adora. The blonde cried into Glimmer's shoulder. Adora's thoughts had been too much for her to handle today. All she wanted was a break from anxiety and trauma. Glimmer whispered into her ear.

"I'm here," Glimmer said. "It's okay. You're safe."

Exhaustion weighed on Adora's body. It would be nice to fall asleep in Glimmer's arms. The blonde's eyes fluttered shut. Soon, she felt Glimmer carrying her into the air. She could hear the queen's wings flapping. Was the shorter woman carrying her? Something was reassuring about being taken care of. A few minutes whizzed by. Eventually, she sensed the bed under her back. She slipped into unconsciousness.

Glimmer pulled the covers over Adora's body. When she looked out the window earlier, she saw Adora fall. At first, the queen thought the blonde passed out. In reality, it was a panic attack. It wasn't the first time Adora had one. Glimmer watched Adora in case something happened. She could push aside royal duties for a while. Glimmer teleported to a bookshelf, grabbed a book, and reappeared on the bed. The queen began reading. Minutes transitioned into an hour as she pored over the pages. At times, her girlfriend mumbled.

After two hours of sleeping, Adora's eyes opened. She glanced at Glimmer, wearing a tired smile. Glimmer shut the book and tucked a strand behind the blonde's ear. It must have been a good nap, as Adora didn't have nightmares. There weren't any more panic attacks. For now, the taller woman was calm.

"Feeling better?" Glimmer asked.

"Yeah. A little tired," Adora said. She peeked at the book. "Were you here the whole time? What about royal duties?"

"I watched you sleep. I had to be sure you were okay. You're important to me, love. You mean everything to me."

"I appreciate your words. And you're my everything, too."

Glimmer took Adora's hand and caressed the blonde's knuckles. "You're so sweet."

Adora moved closer and leaned against Glimmer. "So are you."

Epilogue

Soon, Adora and Glimmer attended therapy sessions. Both women healed from their trauma. As the months passed, nightmares tormented them less often. They learned to cope with their triggers. They overcame the lies they believed about themselves. Adora and Glimmer became closer in their relationship. On occasion, they would hear from Catra. The magicat must have been doing well. As for Hordak, Adora received mixed reports. But the guards kept him under close watch. There wasn't any information regarding Shadow Weaver. Although, there were rumors of her disappearing without a trace. Glimmer hoped the old sorceress wasn't planning something. Adora once had a nightmare about Shadow Weaver returning. Despite their worries, Shadow Weaver didn't show up. An entire year came and went. One day, Adora and Glimmer discussed the blonde's family.

"I still want to know who my biological family is." Adora rested her elbows on the dining table. "Light Hope told me I'm from Eternia."

Glimmer leaned back in her chair. "Are you saying you would go through space to find your family?"

"I might. Can Mara's ship go into space? You told me Entrapta tried to upgrade it."

"She did upgrade the ship." Glimmer sipped her tea. "We didn't launch it."

Adora's gaze drifted to Glimmer's hairstyle. It was short and included an undercut. "Did you get your hair done?"

"Yes. Do you like it?"

"Of course. You're gorgeous no matter what."

"Thanks. And let's get back on topic. What would you say to your family if you met them?"

The question made Adora pause. She had never seen her parents' faces. Were they good parents? Did she have any siblings? Did they know she was gone? Were they hoping to see her again? The only family she had known was Shadow Weaver and Catra. Shadow Weaver had raised Adora and Catra in the Horde. The sorceress abused both women. Hordak didn't care. He sat in his lab the whole time. Shadow Weaver considered Adora special whenever the blonde obeyed. At times, the witch refused to show affection. The Horde looked down on shortcomings. Emotional expression? Listen to harsh lectures. An injury? No breaks. Sickness? Same. Afraid? Twenty-four hours in a dark room.

Would Adora's biological family be different? Sighing, she stared at her mug. She didn't know what she would say to her parents. What should she do? Go up to them and claim to be their missing daughter? Expect them to recognize her at first sight? Tell them what happened to her almost two decades ago? Would she go to Eternia on her own? Or would a friend go with her? Shaking her head, she pushed those thoughts aside. She drank her coffee. The steam wafted into her nose. She became aware of a palm on her forearm. Glimmer observed her body language. Then, the queen made eye contact. Adora's heart skipped a beat.

"You don't have to answer the question," Glimmer said.

A smile tugged at the corners of Adora's lips. "Thanks for the reassurance. It's a personal topic for me."

"I'm sure it is."

"I'd like to go to Eternia."

"I'll go with you."

Adora furrowed her brows. "Don't you have to stay here as queen? I could visit Eternia alone."

Glimmer set her teacup on the table. "I'll ask my father to watch over the kingdom until you and I return."

After the conversation, Adora walked to the couple's bedroom. Adora and Glimmer had been sharing the bed ever since they started dating. She lost count of the times she had fallen asleep in Glimmer's arms. It felt as though Glimmer protected Adora whenever they cuddled. The way Glimmer held her. The way the queen's wings blanketed the couple. Adora hummed to herself as she packed her clothes in a bag. Her mind drifted to the trip. What would Eternia look like? Would it resemble Etheria? Would the people be similar to Etherians? Or different?

Catra panted as she stepped outside. The work was mundane and exhausting. She never had a dull moment. Wake up. Make bricks and other construction materials. Short breaks. And ration bars for mealtimes. On some days, she attended therapy sessions. She couldn't deny that it helped her. Before all this, she had been a cruel Force Captain. The brunette understood the extent of the damage she helped Hordak cause. Speaking of Hordak, she hadn't talked to him for months. Not that she cared. What was he doing now? Did Entrapta still see him? Was Entrapta taking care of Imp? A muscular woman with white hair and red pincers approached. What brought Scorpia here? Did the tall woman need more bricks? As far as Catra knew, some materials were waiting inside the building.

"Hey, wildcat," Scorpia said.

"Hey. You, Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio have one more year left. I got nine years to go. What will you do once you're free?" Catra asked.

"I'd still help out. So will Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio. By the way, do you have more bricks?"

"Yes."

Both women carried the materials to the vehicle. Once they finished moving the supplies, Catra turned her attention to Scorpia. Should she say something? Or should she deny her

feelings for Scorpia? The brunette's tail flicked back and forth. What if Scorpia rejected her? Did Scorpia view her as just a friend? Did the taller woman have feelings for Catra? Catra recalled her friend having a crush on her a few years ago. Back then, she had perceived her as a nuisance. Now, the magicat was okay with her friend's presence.

"I think I have feelings for you," Catra said.

Scorpia arched her brows. "You do?"

"Of course. You're a kind person, and you're strong." Catra crossed her arms. "I don't know if you feel the same. Either way, I accept the answer." She searched Scorpia's eyes for a specific emotion. Instead, the woman appeared to be deep in thought. "You know what, Scorpia? I'll continue working. You take the bricks."

They parted ways for now. Catra made more bricks and other building materials. As the hours whizzed by, she lost herself in thought. Why did she make it awkward for herself and Scorpia? They were better off as just friends. No wonder the taller woman didn't respond. It didn't make sense to read between the lines. However… Would Scorpia friend-zone her? Remain quiet? By sundown, Catra walked to her tent. She reclined on the cot. With time, the answers could come to her. It wouldn't be wise to dwell on it too much. After all, singleness allowed her to work on herself. Closing her eyes, she took deep breaths. It didn't take long for her to drift to dreamland.

…

Catra was racing through the hallway when a shout made her freeze. Shadows emerged from the metal floor. The temperature sank. Silent footsteps approached. She whirled around. Shadow Weaver towered over her, eyes narrowing. Didn't the old sorceress leave? Why were both women in the Fright Zone? Did the Horde somehow revive itself? The witch snatched a Force Captain badge from Catra's shirt. Anger heated her veins as she straightened her

spine. She didn't work hard only to lose the title. Did Hordak order Shadow Weaver to do this?

"For a Force Captain, your performance is egregious. Adora would have been a better leader," Shadow Weaver said.

"Adora's not coming back. That rat spends too much time with the princesses. Sparkles brainwashed her," Catra replied. "They're joined at the hip. No one could separate them!"

"You're the rat. No matter how resistant Adora is, I will bring her home. Her place is in the Horde!"

Catra hissed at the derogatory term. "Fuck you, bitch! We don't need Adora. The Horde needs me! Why don't you care? Why won't anyone give me a chance?"

Dark tendrils snaked around Catra's body, restricting her movements. She struggled to break free. The tentacles pressed into her flesh. Jolts of electricity ripped through her. Tears streamed down her cheeks. Squeezing her eyes shut, she suppressed the oncoming sobs. She hated Shadow Weaver. Loathed the sound of the witch's voice. Her claws extended. The brunette gritted her teeth. Once again, Catra was at Shadow Weaver's mercy. Someday, she would avenge herself. Show everyone what she was made of. And she didn't care who got hurt as a result. People should fear and respect her.

Upon opening her eyes, Catra found herself on a battlefield. Horde soldiers battled the Rebellion. The princesses attacked the bots. Flames licked the tents and greenery. A green glow flooded her vision. It faded, revealing a hallway in Horde Prime's ship. What was going on? One moment, she stood on the battlefield. The next minute, she winded up on the Velvet Glove. Cold laughter echoed. She recognized the voice. Clones strode past, referring to each other as little siblings. She walked to the green pool chamber. Adora wore a white uniform. The blonde held a dark sword. Adora's eyes turned black, resembling empty voids. Rivers of blood trickled down her face. Did something happen?

"You disturbed my peace," Adora said. "I will end you."

…

Catra sat up, hyperventilating. She glimpsed the outlines of furniture and inhaled deeply. It was a nightmare. Shadow Weaver hadn't bothered her for a year. Neither did Hordak and Horde Prime. Catra wiped the sweat off her forehead. Despite those therapy sessions, she still struggled with nightmares. Her therapist would tell her the healing was different for everyone. She wanted to overcome the trauma as soon as possible. And how was Adora doing? Had the blonde healed faster? Maybe Adora did. Catra suspected it was due to the support and safety in Adora's life. Sighing, she grabbed the journal and began writing. The minutes transitioned into an hour.

After riding Mara's ship through space, Adora and Glimmer landed in Eternia. The geography and scenery were similar to Etheria's. There were some differences, such as location names. Castle Grayskull served as a home to a sorceress. Eternos was the capital city. Adora and Glimmer were going to the Royal Palace. The technology and the architecture were advanced. Civilians rode flying vehicles. Skyscrapers stretched into the sky. Entrapta would obsess over this place. Adora glanced around, memorizing the area. She led Glimmer to the Royal Palace's entrance. A pair of guards scrutinized them. One of them told Adora she resembled Prince Adam. Within two minutes, a guard escorted the couple into the throne room. Portraits dotted the walls. Tapestries hung from the ceiling. A woman and a man stood in front of the thrones. The woman wore a green dress and a golden crown. She had reddish-blonde hair. Her nose, lips, and face were the same as Adora's. The man had gray-blue eyes and blonde hair. He wore a red tunic, a blue cape, and a crown.

Adora bowed her head in respect. Glimmer curtsied. Then, they looked up at the king and queen. A young man entered the throne room. His blonde hair had a reddish tint. He wore a pink vest over

a white shirt. Adora made eye contact. He seemed to be her age. She turned her attention to the king and queen.

"I'm Adora. This is Glimmer. We're from Etheria. She's the Queen of Bright Moon," Adora said. "We came to Eternia because I wanted to find my family. When I was a baby, a portal took me to Etheria. That aside, what are your names?"

"You say your name is Adora? Well, we have a daughter with the same name. A portal stole her," the queen said. "I'm Marlena. Their names are Randor and Adam."

Adora recalled the guard's comment regarding resemblances. Was she born to this family? The lost princess of Eternia? What would her childhood have been like if she had grown up here? She clasped her hands together. It wouldn't be right to jump to conclusions. She had never imagined herself as a princess. Perhaps a queen consort if she married Glimmer someday. Other than that, she was sure she didn't have royal blood.

"Is it the same portal? Why didn't it take Adam?" Adora asked.

"Randor and I were able to take Adam to safety. However, we couldn't reach Adora in time," Marlena said.

"Do you think we could be related?"

"Maybe. A DNA test could give us the answers we're searching for."

Once everyone finished the conversation, Adora and the royal couple took a DNA test. A day passed as they waited for the answers. Soon, someone returned with the test results. The truth prompted them to gasp. Marlena cried tears of happiness and relief. Randor pulled her into a side hug. Adora couldn't believe it. She had finally discovered the truth. It was like coming home after a long journey. She knew her true home was in Etheria. Still, she had a biological family on Eternia. Randor, Marlena, and Adam embraced Adora.

"I'm glad you're alive and safe," Marlena said. "Has Glimmer taken care of you?"

"She has. Glimmer took me in when I left the Horde," Adora replied. "Glimmer and I are dating. She saved me several times."

Randor looked at Glimmer. "You kept my daughter safe, didn't you?"

Glimmer nodded. "I did. By the way, Adora and I saved Etheria. She can transform into She-Ra."

Adam glanced at Adora. "You transform into She-Ra?"

Adora pushed her hands into her pockets. "Yeah. What's interesting about it?"

"I have an alter-ego, too. He-Man. I defend Eternia from bad guys such as Skeletor and Evil-Lyn."

"Is that it? I fought Horde soldiers, battled Catra, and redirected a beam of light at Shadow Weaver. And I defeated Horde Prime, ending the war."

Glimmer stepped closer and took Adora's hand. "I helped her fight Horde Prime."

Adam rested a hand on his hip. "Was Horde Prime powerful?"

Adora shrugged. "Horde Prime led a galactic empire to Etheria. Controlled people using chips on their necks. And he could fight. He uses his hair tubes and finger tentacles as weapons. When it comes to choking, he has a strong grip. What does all this sound like to you?"

"He must have put up quite a fight. Can you tell me more about yourself?"

"Sure. I grew up in the Horde. Shadow Weaver mentored me. She raised me and Catra for almost two decades. She abused us. One

night, I found the Sword of Protection in the Whispering Woods. At the time, Glimmer saw me. Her childhood friend Bow accompanied her. They fought me, then tied me up. As I spent time with them, they mentioned the Horde's cruelty. Everything they told me went against what Shadow Weaver taught me. Later on, the Horde attacked a village. I saved people and left the Horde. Glimmer and I formed the Princess Alliance. One time, Shadow Weaver attempted to wipe my memories. Glimmer knocked her out. Glimmer and I went on missions a lot. After she lost her mother to the interdimensional portal, she inherited the throne. We argued a lot."

"Did things get any better? How did Glimmer respond to her loss?"

"Glimmer couldn't find time to process her grief. Things got worse. She activated the Heart of Etheria. I broke the sword, and Horde Prime captured me."

Adam frowned. "How did the captivity make you feel?"

Adora sighed. "It was isolating. I had missed my home and my friends. Catra would visit my cell sometimes and taunt me. At one point, I tried to escape. I was close to getting away, but Catra ambushed me. Horde Prime told his clones to 'purify' me. They chipped me against my consent." She struggled to find a word that would describe the situation. "It's a harrowing experience. They stole my free will. My memories were either gone or suppressed. It felt as if something else took control of my actions. Horde Prime did it to me. He intended to use me as a weapon."

"It sounds awful. You must have been scared."

"I was panicking. No one was there to rescue me."

"Did Glimmer get you out of there?"

Adora wrapped an arm around Glimmer's shoulders. "She came to me in the woods. The princesses were with her. They fought my mind-controlled self. Glimmer's words broke through to me. I

removed the chip from my neck. We spent the rest of the war freeing Etheria. One night, I snuck out to face Horde Prime on my own. He was about to finish me off. Glimmer stopped him. I transformed into She-Ra. Together, we stopped him and saved the universe. I'm so glad to have Glimmer in my life. She's an awesome girlfriend and queen."

Adam smiled. "I can tell how much you love her. Do you see yourself marrying her in the future?"

"Definitely. There's no one else I'd rather be with. And Glimmer's the best thing that ever happened to me."

"Let me know when you're getting married."

"I will. It's nice getting to know you. Glimmer and I are returning to Etheria soon."

Randor and Marlena hugged Adora. So did Adam. The family remained still for several seconds. Adora said "goodbye" to them and led Glimmer out of the palace. She grabbed Glimmer's hand. They strode out of town.

Upon landing in Etheria, Glimmer dwelled on a plan for Adora. Someday, she would pop the question. For now, she needed to find a perfect location. The Whispering Woods might be a decent place. It was where she met Adora for the first time. However, there were other beautiful locations in Etheria worth visiting. The date had to go smoothly. As for the ring, she would have to get something Adora would love. As the royal responsibilities intensified, she whizzed through her busy days. In her free time, she would ask people about ideal proposal locations. Some suggested waterfalls. Others said the beach was perfect. She made a list of each place.

One day, Glimmer decided. The queen had chosen the ring and the location. She teleported Adora to a beach by the lake. The water shimmered in broad sunlight. Glimmer and Adora wore

swimsuits in case they wanted to swim. A ray of light caressed the taller woman's hair, creating a golden halo. Adora's hair had grown longer. Blonde strands swayed in the breeze. Glimmer opened the picnic basket and opened two jars of iced tea.

"Has anyone told you how gorgeous you are?" Glimmer asked.

"You did," Adora said, cheeks reddening. "You're beautiful, too."

"Thanks." Glimmer took out a pair of sandwiches. She handed one to Adora. "Here you go."

Adora grabbed the sandwich and took a bite. "Thank you. You plan the best dates, don't you?"

"Well, what can I say? I enjoy taking you to scenic locations." Glimmer sipped her drink. "Plus, it's nice to leave the castle sometimes."

"Yeah. And I enjoy all our dates. You're so romantic."

"You're too cute to leave behind on little adventures." Glimmer moved closer and leaned against Adora. "No, wait. You're adorable."

Adora chuckled. "You're so sweet."

"So are you."

Glimmer and Adora continued eating their food. They exchanged compliments. The queen slid her hands into her pockets. One held a velvety ring box. Now was the perfect time to propose. She gazed at the clouds. How would she go about doing it? Pull out the ring and ask those four words? Wait for Adora to talk? An era of peace was the ideal time to marry. No wars, no danger, and no fear of losing someone. With that making sense, Glimmer yanked the ring box from her pocket. Adora peeked at the box in the queen's hands. Would the blonde say yes?

"Adora…" Glimmer began. "When I look into your eyes, I see the person I want to spend my life with. No one will cherish you more than I will. I love you with my whole heart." She opened the box, revealing a golden ring with an amethyst. Tiny diamonds lined the sides of the gem. "Princess Adora of Eternia… the hero of Etheria… Will you marry me?"

Adora's eyes shone with tears as she glanced at the ring. "Glim… I want to share my life with you. I love you, too. Of course I'll marry you!" She kissed Glimmer's cheek. "You're my true love and my soulmate."

Glimmer slid the ring onto Adora's finger. "Soon, we'll be wives. We'll watch over Etheria together. The future will be bright."

"I can't wait to marry you."

Glimmer and Adora finished their meal. The queen stole glances at the blonde. From time to time, Adora smiled at the engagement ring. The couple continued chatting. After dessert, they stepped into the cool water. Waves lapped their bodies as they proceeded deeper. Adora held Glimmer's hand.

"It feels nice," Adora said. "Smooth stones beneath feet. Pleasant water temperature on a beautiful day. The amount of serenity out here."

"It's even better when you're here with me," Glimmer said. "You make me feel like the luckiest girl on Etheria."

"Same. We complete each other."

"We absolutely do. I'm so happy you came into my life. We'll go through life together. Our future will be amazing. You are mine, and I am yours."

"No truer words spoken, my queen. You're the love of my life. My heart is yours."

Their special day came. Adora wore a long, flowing gown that swept across the floor. Golden accents lined the neckline and waist. The neckline stopped just above her chest. A golden tiara rested on her head. Its red gem twinkled. The servants had pulled her hair back into a single braid. Teardrop earrings dangled from her earlobes. She couldn't wait to see how Glimmer looked. The blonde was sure the queen would be breathtaking. Adam entered the room, wearing a tuxedo. He would escort her down the aisle.

"Ready, sis?" Adam asked.

"I am," Adora replied.

"Let's go. Your queen is waiting."

Adora looped an arm around Adam's. They walked into a large hall, where everyone sat. Bow wore a formal crop top. Perfuma was decked out in her person of honor attire. Glimmer waited in front of the arch, wearing a regal kimono. Everyone stood as they watched Adam lead Adora down the aisle. A few people whispered. For a moment, Adora was self-conscious about the pink scars on her back. However, no one seemed to notice. Perhaps the guests were discussing how gorgeous she looked.

As Adora approached Glimmer, they held hands. Adam walked to an empty seat next to Teela's. Adora couldn't help but smile. Glimmer grinned, too. Micah began talking to the audience. Adora caressed Glimmer's cheek. The queen leaned into the touch. It was now time for the couple to exchange vows.

"Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon, I take you to be my wife. I will stand by you and take care of you. I will make you the happiest woman in Etheria," Adora said. "You're strong and compassionate. My queen, I will always love you."

"Princess Adora of Eternia, I take you to be my wife. My star, I will always be with you. You're kind and brave. My heart belongs to you forever," Glimmer said.

Adora and Glimmer leaned in. Their mouths met. The crowd erupted into cheers. Adora wrapped her arms around Glimmer's waist. After exchanging the vows, the couple walked to a photography room. The photographer took dozens of pictures. Adora and Glimmer came up with every pose. They hoped they would frame one of those pictures.

An hour passed. Adora and Glimmer cut the cake together. They fed each other small pieces. Soon, it was time for the dance. They held each other as they swayed to the music. Adora gazed into Glimmer's eyes.

"We're married now," Adora said.

"Yeah. By the way, you look like a queen," Glimmer replied.

"Thanks. You do, too."

"You make me happy every day."

"Has anyone told you that you're a great kisser?"

"Only you. Also, your lips are so soft."

Their faces inched closer. Adora's lips brushed Glimmer's. The queen melted into the embrace. They continued dancing. There were twirls, dips, and more kisses.

For many years, the two queens ruled together. They ensured the land would remain in an era of peace. As a result, there were no more wars in Etheria.

The End.

End Notes

Comments/kudos appreciated! 🙂

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